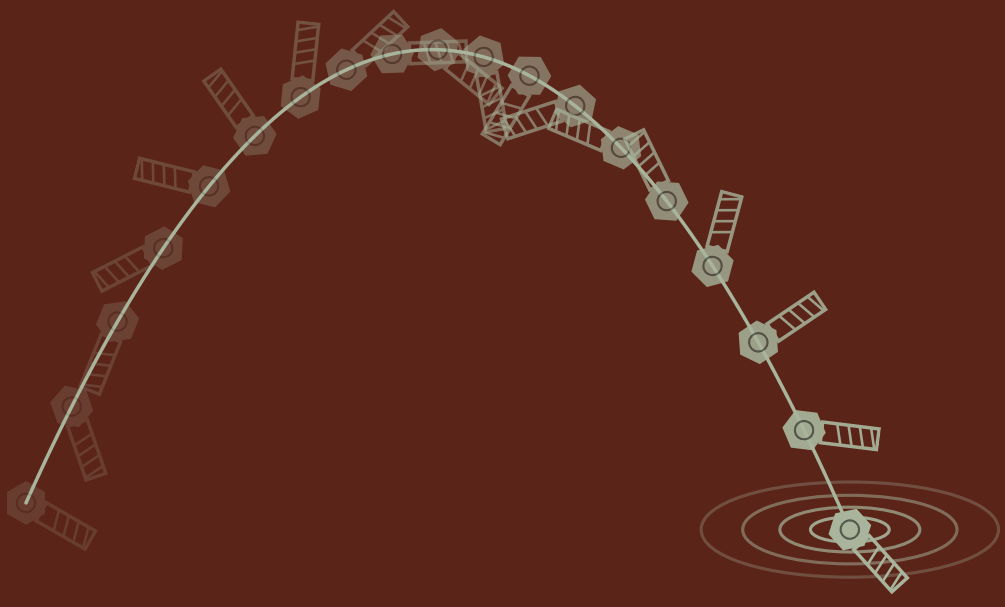


The Ballistics of Abandonment

Thrownness, Temptation, and the Ordeal of the Wish in GSC Game World's S.T.A.L.K.E.R.

Toward a Peirastic Materialism

A Doctoral Thesis
October 2026

Abstract

This thesis undertakes an exhaustive philosophical, genealogical, and comparative exegesis of the *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* series developed by GSC Game World (Kyiv; *Shadow of Chernobyl*, 2007; *Clear Sky*, 2008; *Call of Pripyat*, 2009; *Heart of Chornobyl*, 2024). It argues that the series' Zone constitutes the most comprehensive late-modern synthesis of three otherwise disjunct inheritances: the anti-anthropocentric science fiction of Arkady and Boris Strugatsky and its theological transfiguration in Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979); the noospheric and Cosmist metaphysics of the Russian-Soviet scientific imaginary (Vernadsky, Fyodorov, Tsiolkovsky, Bogdanov, and, by Francophone affinity, Teilhard de Chardin); and the material, political, and ecological catastrophe of Chornobyl, read through the post-Soviet transition and, latterly, Russia's war against Ukraine.

Part I reconstructs these genealogies, distinguishing documented filiation from elective affinity. Part II offers a systematic exegesis of the Zone's topology, its epistemology of anomaly, its material culture of artifacts, its bestiary, the political theology of its factions, its terminal mythology (the Wish Granter and the C-Consciousness), and the structure of its protagonist. Part III traces the series' later inflections and situates the Zone within a fourfold comparative typology (zones of visitation, catastrophe, exception, and transfiguration) spanning Lovecraft, Lem, Ballard, Pynchon, Le Guin, Tolstaya, and VanderMeer, the ludic tradition from *Fallout* to *Metro 2033*, and the mythic patterns of katabasis, the Grail, the wish-tale, and Gnostic anamnesis.

Part IV advances an original thesis. The Zone is a *peirastērion*, a place of trial, organized by a **ballistic ontology**: a convergent lexicon of throwing (Greek *ballein*; Russian *бросать*, *выброс*, *заброшенность*; Ukrainian *кинути*, *викид*, *покинутий*; German *Wurf*, *Geworfenheit*, *Entwurf*; the Valentinian *eneblēthēmen*, "we were thrown in") binds thrownness, abandonment, emission, refuse, and probe into a single figure. Within this peirastērion the four dominant modern responses to the unknown, namely the Wish, the Plan, the Creed, and the Idol, are exposed as *diabolic* in the etymological sense (*dia-ballein*, to throw apart). Against them, the stalker's thrown bolt (*pro-ballein*, whence *problem*) and the campfire's inoperative community (*sym-ballein*, whence *symbol*) articulate an alternative here termed **peirastic materialism**: an epistemology of apophatic probing, an ethics of risk-bearing finitude, and a politics of the commons.

Particular attention is paid to what the thesis calls the **algorithmic Room**: *Shadow of Chernobyl*'s computation of its false endings from the player's accumulated con-

duct rather than from any declared choice. This mechanism is read as the procedural realization of Tarkovsky's Room, of Dostoevsky's three temptations, and of Spinoza's critique of the will, through which play itself becomes *peirasmos*, at once trial and temptation. Freedom, in the Zone, is withheld from the wisher and granted to the questioner. The thesis concludes that *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* stages the terminal ordeal of modern futurity, and that its enduring legacy is not an answer to the Zone but a gesture for inhabiting it: the bolt in flight.

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Prefatory Note: Corpus, Transliteration, Abbreviations

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the four canonical releases of GSC Game World: *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.: Shadow of Chernobyl* (2007; hereafter **SoC**), *Clear Sky* (2008; **CS**), *Call of Pripyat* (2009; **CoP**), and *S.T.A.L.K.E.R. 2: Heart of Chornobyl* (2024; **HoC**). Unmodified releases are treated as canonical; the modding tradition is treated as a cultural phenomenon in its own right only in Chapter 14. The principal literary and cinematic sources are Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (*Пикник на обочине*, 1972; **RP**) and Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979; ***St.***). Because the games' narratives are partly emergent, descriptions refer to canonical scripted content; dialogue is paraphrased rather than reproduced, and direct quotation is confined to texts in the public domain.

Transliteration and toponymy. Russian and Ukrainian are romanized after a simplified Library of Congress system, with Cyrillic retained where the argument turns on a word's morphology. Historical places follow Ukrainian romanization (Chornobyl, Kyiv, Prypiat); diegetic places retain the games' English localization (Pripyat, Yantar, Rostok, Zaton). The doubled spelling is deliberate. The franchise itself moved from *Chernobyl* to *Chornobyl* in 2022, and the distance between the two orthographies is one of this thesis's objects.

Filiation and affinity. Two kinds of relation are kept strictly apart. *Filiation* denotes documented or textually manifest derivation: the Strugatskian vocabulary of Zone, stalker, artifact, and wish-granting centre; Tarkovsky's bolt-throwing and Room; the topography and history of Chornobyl; the Duga radar; the noospheric idiom that the series itself voices. *Affinity*, in the sense Goethe gave *Wahlverwandtschaft* and Max Weber made methodological, denotes structural correspondence that claims no authorial intention: Dostoevsky's Inquisitor, the Gnostic *Hymn of the Pearl*, Propp's morphology, Heidegger's thrownness. Readings of affinity are offered as hermeneutic constructions, and their force rests on the density of correspondence rather than on biography.

Citation. References are given in author–date form, with full entries under Works Cited. Dates are of first publication or release. Where composition preceded publication by many years, as with works suppressed by censorship or published posthumously, the entry gives both. Translations are cited where the argument depends on them.

Introduction

The Zone as Philosophical Object

0.1 A Landscape Inherited

The Zone is the last great philosophical landscape of the twentieth century, and *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* is the medium through which the twenty-first century took possession of it. The inheritance passed through five conversions, each of which changed the ontological status of the territory. In 1972 the Strugatskys imagined a Zone as the residue of an alien indifference, a hypothesis about humanity's insignificance in a cosmos that does not notice it. In 1979 Tarkovsky converted that hypothesis into a spiritual threshold, a landscape in which the question was no longer what the visitors had left but what the visitor wants. In 1986 history converted the fictional threshold into a real exclusion: the explosion of Reactor No. 4 at the Chornobyl Nuclear Power Plant produced a territory that Soviet administrative language named, with unintended philosophical precision, a *zone of alienation*. In 2007 GSC Game World, working some hundred kilometres from that territory in Kyiv, converted the real exclusion into a playable world, superimposing the Strugatskian fiction, the Tarkovskian theology, and the Chornobyl topography into a single navigable space. In 2024, completed under the conditions of Russia's full-scale invasion, whose forces had occupied the real Zone in the war's first weeks, *Heart of Chornobyl* converted the playable world into a theatre of national survival.

No other landscape of modern fiction has undergone so many changes of state while retaining its name. Modernism itself had opened in 1913 with Apollinaire's "Zone," the poem that placed at the head of *Alcools* a weary wanderer through a city in which the ancient world had become tiresome ("À la fin tu es las de ce monde ancien"). The century closed with a Zone in which the *new* world had become ancient: a city built in 1970 as a showpiece of atomic futurity, its amusement park scheduled to open on 1 May 1986, frozen five days short of its inauguration. Between the two Zones lies the twentieth century's whole archive of enclosure. The word *zona* named the Soviet penal camp in the argot of its prisoners; *Interessengebiet* named the cordon of SS ad-

ministration around Auschwitz; Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) named "the Zone" the post-imperial interregnum of occupied Germany; Parisian slang named *la zone* the shantytown belt beyond the city walls. The Zone is the topos in which modernity records the places it has excluded, and the excluded places in which modernity's truth accumulates.

The present thesis takes this landscape as a philosophical object in the strict sense: not a setting that illustrates philosophical ideas, but a structure in which philosophical problems acquire material, narrative, and, decisively, *procedural* form. A video game does not merely represent; it enacts rules that the player must inhabit. Ian Bogost (2007) calls this capacity procedural rhetoric; Alexander Galloway (2006) reads games as allegories of control in which playing the game means learning the logic of its code; Espen Aarseth (1997) describes the ergodic text as one that demands non-trivial effort to traverse. *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* is philosophically singular among games because its central problems are encoded in its mechanics rather than its cutscenes. Its A-Life simulation sustains a world that proceeds without the player, giving computational form to what Eugene Thacker (2011) calls the world-without-us. Its bolt-throwing mechanic converts an epistemology into a gesture. Its artifact economy literalizes the commodity fetish. Its factions stage a political theology. Most strikingly, its first instalment computes the protagonist's terminal wish from the player's accumulated conduct, so that the game, like Tarkovsky's Room, grants not what one says one wants but what one has shown oneself to want.

0.2 Corpus, Method, and the Problem of Filiation

The method of this thesis is fivefold. It is **genealogical** in the Nietzschean and Foucauldian sense: it traces descent (*Herkunft*) rather than origin (*Ursprung*), attending to the accidents, mistranslations, and repurposings through which the Zone's vocabulary passed from Leningrad to Mosfilm to Kyiv. It is **comparative**, situating the Zone within a typology of analogous spaces in speculative, mythological, and philosophical fiction. It is **philological**, treating the morphology of key words as evidence of conceptual structure, in the manner of Reinhart Koselleck's conceptual history and of Heidegger's etymological thinking, though without the latter's claims to originary truth. It is **mythographic**, drawing on Propp, Eliade, van Gennep, and Campbell while treating their universalizing schemata as heuristics rather than laws. It is **ludological**, reading mechanics as arguments.

These methods converge on what Walter Benjamin, in the epistemo-critical prologue to his study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928), called the constellation: ideas relate to phenomena as constellations relate to stars, configuring scattered points into a figure without reducing them to a concept. The thesis's constellations are partly chronological. The year **1972** saw the publication of *Roadside Picnic*, of the Club of Rome's *The Limits to Growth*, of René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré*, and the release

of Tarkovsky's *Solaris*. The year **1979** saw the release of *Stalker*, the partial meltdown at Three Mile Island in March, the Strugatskys' *Beetle in the Anthill*, Carlo Ginzburg's essay on the evidential paradigm, Jean-François Lyotard's *La Condition postmoderne*, Hans Jonas's *Das Prinzip Verantwortung*, and Coppola's *Apocalypse Now*. The year **1986** saw Chornobyl, the publication of Ulrich Beck's *Risikogesellschaft*, Fredric Jameson's essay on national allegory, and Tarkovsky's death in Paris on 29 December. These coincidences establish no causation. They establish a field of force within which the Zone became thinkable.

The problem of filiation is acute for a commercial artefact produced by a large team over a protracted development cycle, announced in 2001 under the subtitle *Oblivion Lost*. The thesis therefore distinguishes, as the Prefatory Note specifies, between documented filiation and elective affinity. It does not claim that GSC's designers read Valentinian fragments or Proppian morphology. It claims that the Zone, as a cultural form condensed from Soviet science fiction, Orthodox spirituality, Cosmist metaphysics, post-Soviet political economy, and East Slavic folklore, carries structures that those texts illuminate, and that the density of correspondence is itself evidence of the form's philosophical seriousness. Jameson's notion of the political unconscious (1981) licenses the reading of a text as the symbolic resolution of contradictions its producers need not have articulated. The Zone is such a resolution, and its contradictions are those of a civilization that planned the future and was buried by it.

0.3 The Argument: Peirastērion and Ballistic Ontology

The thesis advances five linked claims.

First, the Zone is governed by a ballistic ontology. Everything in it has been thrown. The city has been thrown away: the Russian *заброшенный* and the Ukrainian *покинутий*, both meaning "abandoned," derive respectively from *бросать* and *кинути*, "to throw." The Emission, the Zone's periodic cataclysm, is a throwing-out: Russian *выброс*, Ukrainian *викид*. The alien residue of the Strugatskian Visitation is refuse, what has been thrown off (*отбросы*). The protagonist is thrown into the Zone from a truck of corpses, a literalization of Heidegger's *Geworfenheit*, which Russian philosophical usage renders as *заброшенность* or *брошенность*, the very word for an abandoned place. And the stalker knows the Zone only by throwing: the bolt, cast ahead to reveal the anomaly by its deviation, is the minimal unit of knowledge in the series. The English "abandon," from the Old French *à bandon*, "under the ban," completes the figure: as Jean-Luc Nancy (1983) and Giorgio Agamben (1995) argue, to be abandoned is to be placed under a sovereign ban, exposed rather than expelled.

Second, the Zone is a *peirastērion*. The coinage follows the Greek morphology by which *-tērion* designates a place of action (*dikastērion*, court of justice; *ergastērion*, workshop; *mystērion*; *phylaktērion*, guard-post and amulet; *hilastērion*, place of propitiation). A *peirastērion* is the place of *peirazein*, of testing and tempting. In Aristotle's

Sophistical Refutations (165b), peirastic arguments are those that examine a claim to knowledge. In Matthew 4:3 the devil is *ho peirazōn*, the tempter, and the Lord's Prayer asks not to be led *eis peirasmon*. The root *peira*, trial, gives Greek *empeiria* (experience) and *peiratēs* (one who attempts, the pirate); its Indo-European cognates give Latin *periculum* and *experiri*, English *peril*, *experience*, *experiment*, *expert*, and, through Germanic, *fear* and German *Gefahr*. Heidegger observed that *Erfahrung*, experience, belongs with *fahren*, to travel: to experience is to obtain something on a way. East Slavic morphology repeats the convergence. Russian *опыт* (experience, experiment), *испытание* (trial, ordeal), and *пытка* (torture) share the root of *пытать*, to try, to question; and *следопыт*, the native word for tracker, is literally "one who interrogates the trace." The Zone is the place where all these senses coincide: where experience is peril, where experiment is torture, where trial is temptation, and where the tracker interrogates traces at the risk of death.

Third, the modern responses to the unknown are diabolic. The Greek *diaballein*, to throw across, to set at odds, to slander, gives *diabolos*. In the Zone four great responses to the unknown are tried and found diabolic in this exact sense, because each throws apart the subject from others and from the real: the **Wish** (private desire, embodied in the Wish Granter and continuous with the logic of capital); the **Plan** (collective engineering of human nature, embodied in the C-Consciousness and continuous with the Cosmist and Soviet perfectibility projects); the **Creed** (ideological militancy, embodied in Duty and Freedom); and the **Idol** (fanatical submission, embodied in the Monolith). Against these the series sets three non-diabolic throws: the bolt, a *problem* in the etymological sense (*proballein*, to throw forward); the campfire, a *symbol* (*symballein*, to throw together); and the anecdote told at the fire, a *parable* (*paraballein*, to throw beside).

Fourth, the game makes the peirastērion playable. *Shadow of Chernobyl* determines which of its five false endings the player receives from accumulated parameters of conduct rather than from any declared choice, while reserving a genuine decision for the player who has discovered the hidden path to the Zone's true centre. The thesis calls this mechanism the **algorithmic Room**. It realizes procedurally the principle that Tarkovsky's Stalker states through the parable of Porcupine, that the Room grants the innermost wish rather than the professed one; it stages Dostoevsky's three temptations; and it vindicates Spinoza's critique of the will, since the wisher who believes himself free is shown to be the sum of his conduct. Freedom, in the Zone, is withheld from the wisher and granted to the questioner, as the Grail is withheld from the knight who fails to ask.

Fifth, the series supplies a fifth answer to the wish-granting centre. The novel answers with *apokatastasis*, the universal wish that no one be left out; the film answers with *apophasis*, the threshold not crossed; *Shadow of Chernobyl* answers with *iconoclasm*, the destruction of the false centre; *Heart of Chornobyl* answers with the question of *sovereignty*, who shall rule the Zone. The stalker's own practice, extracted from

the four works and theorized here, answers with *peirasis*: to probe, to bear the risk, and to return.

The thesis names the resulting stance **peirastic materialism**. The phrase is chosen against two predecessors. Against Soviet dialectical materialism, which held that matter obeys knowable laws of development, peirastic materialism retains the materialism and abandons the law: the Zone is matter in open insubordination, knowable only by trial. Against the new materialism of Jane Bennett's *Vibrant Matter* (2010), whose agentic matter is largely benign, peirastic materialism insists that matter's agency is lethal before it is vibrant, and that the ethics proper to it is not enchantment but the disciplined bearing of risk.

0.4 Plan of the Thesis

Part I reconstructs the genealogies. Chapter 1 analyses *Roadside Picnic* and the wider Strugatsky corpus. Chapter 2 analyses Tarkovsky's *Stalker*. Chapter 3 treats Chornobyl as event, territory, and revelation. Chapter 4 reconstructs the noospheric and Cosmist metaphysics that the series inherits and indicts.

Part II offers a systematic exegesis. Chapter 5 maps the Zone's topologies. Chapter 6 develops the ballistic hermeneutics of the thrown bolt. Chapter 7 theorizes the artifact as *hylophany* and reads the bestiary as a teratology of degenerate modernity. Chapter 8 analyses the political theology of the factions. Chapter 9 analyses the Wish Granter and the algorithmic Room. Chapter 10 reads the C-Consciousness as a noospheric Grand Inquisitor. Chapter 11 analyses Strelok as branded hero, amnesiac, and Gnostic pneumatic.

Part III follows the later Zone through *Clear Sky*, *Call of Pripyat*, and *Heart of Chornobyl* (Chapter 12) and constructs a comparative typology of zones (Chapter 13). **Part IV** (Chapter 14) assembles the synthesis, culminating in twelve theses on peirastic materialism, and a Conclusion considers the Zone's lessons for a planetary condition in which the cordon has dissolved.

Part

I

Genealogies



Part I reconstructs the four inheritances condensed in the Zone: the Strugatskian fiction that supplied its vocabulary, the Tarkovskian theology that supplied its interiority, the Chornobyl catastrophe that supplied its ground, and the noospheric metaphysics that supplied its demiurge. Each is read for what the series takes from it and for what the series turns against it.



Chapter 1

The Strugatskian Matrix: *Roadside Picnic* and the Ethics of Extraction

1.1 The Visitation and the Picnic Hypothesis

Roadside Picnic gives the Zone its first and most radical ontology: the Zone is refuse. Written in 1971 and serialized in 1972 in the Leningrad journal *Avrora*, the novel posits a Visitation, a brief extraterrestrial presence at six sites on Earth, after which each site becomes a Zone saturated with lethal anomalies and inexplicable artifacts. The narrative centres on the Zone adjoining Harmont, a deliberately non-Soviet, Anglophone town, and on the International Institute of Extraterrestrial Cultures established to study it. In the novel's most quoted conversation, the Nobel laureate Valentine Pilman offers a hypothesis about the visitors' intentions. Imagine, he suggests, travellers who pull off a country road for a picnic and leave behind their trash: spent matches, an oil slick, a lost tool. The animals and insects of the meadow, returning, find a landscape transfigured by objects whose purpose they cannot conceive and which were never meant for them.

The picnic hypothesis is the most thorough decentring of humanity in Soviet science fiction. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) had made contact impossible; the Strugatskys made it *unintended*. Lem's ocean at least returns something addressed to its observers, the materialized "guests" drawn from their guilt. The Strugatskian visitors address no one. Lem recognized the kinship: he wrote an afterword for the novel's German edition of 1977. Humanity is not the interlocutor of the cosmos but the fauna of its verge. The theological consequence is severe: the Zone is not a revelation, since revelation implies an addressee, but a *residue*, and the human labour of interpretation that it provokes is the labour of ants upon a bottle cap. The Russian word for refuse, *отбросы*, "things thrown off," already contains the ballistic figure this thesis will pursue: the Zone begins as what has been discarded.

Darko Suvin's *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction* (1979), whose criteria the Strugatskys' work helped to shape, defined the genre by cognitive estrangement organized

around a *novum*, a historically new element validated by cognitive logic. The Zone is a novum of a peculiar kind. It estranges, but it refuses cognitive closure: the Institute's science accumulates data without explanation, and the novel ends without disclosing what the visitors were. The Zone might therefore be called an *incognitive novum*, a novelty whose function is to expose the limits of the cognition it summons. This structure passes intact into GSC's series, whose scientists at Yantar measure everything and understand nothing, and whose anomalies remain, across four games, phenomenologically catalogued but causally opaque.

1.2 Redrick Schuhart and the Proletariat of the Anomaly

Redrick "Red" Schuhart, laboratory assistant by day and stalker by night, is the prototype of the series' protagonist, and he is above all a worker. His relation to the Zone is extraction: he enters illegally, retrieves objects at mortal risk, and sells them through intermediaries to buyers whose purposes he suspects but cannot control. The novel stages two modes of appropriation, the state-scientific (the Institute, whose access is legal, equipped, and safe) and the market (smugglers, fences, and the corporate and military interests behind them), and positions the stalker between them as the one who bears the risk that both monetize. Red's body is the interface at which the Zone's lethality is converted into value. In this he anticipates with uncanny exactness the political economy of GSC's Zone, in which the trader Sidorovich, sealed in his bunker at the Cordon, pays a pittance for artifacts that rookies die to retrieve.

The word *stalker* itself is an English import into Russian. Boris Strugatsky recorded that it was borrowed from Rudyard Kipling's *Stalky & Co.* (1899), whose schoolboy hero outwits his masters by cunning. The genealogy is apt. The stalker's characteristic intelligence is what Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant, in *Les Ruses de l'intelligence* (1974), reconstructed as Greek *mētis*: the oblique, anticipatory, practical cunning of the hunter, the fisherman, and the pilot, exercised in fluid situations where rules fail and only attentiveness to signs preserves life. The stalker is a master of *mētis* in a world without *nomos*. GSC's acronym, whose expansion as Scavengers, Trespassers, Adventurers, Loners, Killers, Explorers, Robbers the publisher THQ revealed only in early 2007, is in this respect a faithful gloss: every term names a relation of trespass against a law, and none names a relation of obedience. The gloss came last: Kipling's schoolboy nickname became the Strugatskys' noun, Tarkovsky's holy fool, GSC's title, and finally, in the publisher's marketing, a backronym.

1.3 The Meatgrinder and the Sphere

The novel's final chapter supplies the moral template for every wish-granting centre that follows. Red guides Arthur, the son of his former mentor Vulture Burbridge, to the Golden Sphere said to grant wishes, knowing that the passage is guarded by the Meatgrinder, an anomaly that destroys the first to cross it. Arthur, exultant, runs

ahead crying out a wish for universal happiness and is annihilated. Red reaches the Sphere and discovers that he cannot formulate a wish of his own: the only words available to him are the brutal vocabulary of his life. He ends by repeating the boy's words, a wish for happiness for everyone, given freely, so that no one departs aggrieved. The novel closes on the utterance and withholds its effect.

The structure is sacrificial and universalist at once, and its intertexts form a precise constellation. Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) read Abraham's ascent of Moriah as the teleological suspension of the ethical; Red's ascent is Moriah without the ram, the sacrifice consummated. Dostoevsky's Ivan Karamazov, in the chapter "Rebellion" (1880), had asked whether universal harmony could be accepted if built on the unavenged tears of a single tortured child, and had returned his ticket. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), published a year after the novel and derived, by her own account, from William James's image of a happiness purchased by one soul's lonely torment, turned the same question into a parable of complicity. That Le Guin later wrote the foreword to Olena Bormashenko's 2012 translation of *Roadside Picnic* closes the circle: the author of the sacrificed child of Omelas prefaced the sacrificed boy of the Zone.

Red's wish is eschatologically an *apokatastasis*, the restoration of all things (Acts 3:21) that Origen extended to universal salvation, so that no creature is finally lost. But it is uttered over a corpse. The novel's ethical genius lies in refusing to adjudicate whether the universal wish redeems the sacrifice or is condemned by it. Red's aphasia before the Sphere is equally significant: desire, for the Strugatskys, is articulated in the language of one's world, and a deformed world yields a deformed vocabulary of desire. GSC will mechanize this insight. In *Shadow of Chernobyl* the wish is not spoken at all; it is computed from the life that produced it.

1.4 Revenants and the Child of the Zone

Two figures in the novel register the Zone's penetration of the family and furnish GSC's bestiary with its moral grammar. The first is the revenant. The dead buried in the Zone's cemeteries rise and walk home, and Red's own father returns to sit mute in his son's house. This is Nikolai Fyodorov's "common task" of resurrecting the ancestors, the founding dream of Russian Cosmism, fulfilled as horror: the fathers return as bodies without spirit, presences without communion. W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902) had already dramatized the knock of the wished-for dead at the door. The Zone answers the wish for resurrection by sending back the corpse. GSC's zombified stalkers, who wander muttering fragments of their former speech, are the direct descendants of this figure, and their very muttering is the Fyodorovian revenant given a broken voice.

The second figure is Red's daughter, called Monkey, born with a fine fur and progressively less human, losing speech as she gains an alien serenity. Monkey is the

Zone inherited in the flesh. Tarkovsky retains her as the crippled child who may possess telekinetic power; GSC generalizes her into the entire mutant population. The ethical problem she poses is kinship with the monstrous: the mutant is not an invader but an offspring, and the stalker who kills mutants is never entirely free of the suspicion that he is killing kin.

1.5 The Wider Corpus: Forests, Homeostasis, Sarcophagi, Ludens

The Zone's genealogy extends beyond *Roadside Picnic* into the Strugatskys' wider corpus, whose works of the later 1960s and 1970s turned from the communist utopia of the Noon cycle toward its residues. *The Snail on the Slope* (first drafted in 1965, published in two parts in 1966 and 1968, then banned, and printed complete in the USSR only in 1988) juxtaposes an incomprehensible biological Forest with the Directorate, a bureaucracy that studies, administers, and fails to understand it, the first iteration of the pairing of anomalous territory and institutional observer that runs through GSC's Institute-like scientists and military cordons and reappears in Jeff VanderMeer's Southern Reach. Its scientist hero, Peretz, is refused a permit to enter the Forest again and again, the first Strugatskian figure of the cordon; and the novel suffered an exclusion of its own, kept from Soviet readers as a whole for twenty years. *Definitely Maybe* (1976–1977) posits a "homeostatic Universe" that defends its equilibrium against discoveries threatening it, harassing scientists with inexplicable interference; *Clear Sky*'s premise that the Zone answers intrusion toward its centre with Emissions is this homeostasis rendered as gameplay.

Beetle in the Anthill (1979) is the most startling anticipation. Its premise concerns a *sarcophagus* left by the vanished Wanderers, containing human embryos who grow into foundlings suspected of carrying alien programming; one of them, Lev Abalkin, unaware of what he may be, is hunted and finally killed by the security chief Sikorski at the moment he approaches the object linked to his origin. The sarcophagus was unearthed by the Pathfinders, the Noon universe's corps of explorers, whose Russian name, sledopyty, is the native word for tracker that Chapter 6 reads beside stalker; and the authors later insisted that Abalkin was an ordinary man who simply wanted to learn the truth about himself. He is the questioner of Chapter 9 in his first form. Seven years before the Chornobyl Sarcophagus and twenty-eight before GSC placed its demiurge inside that Sarcophagus, the Strugatskys had imagined an unwitting programmed agent, a containment called a sarcophagus, and a security apparatus that prefers preventive murder to the risk of the unknown. The Marked One, implanted with the order to kill Strelok and ignorant that he is Strelok, is Abalkin's ludic heir.

The Doomed City (written 1970–1975, published 1988–1989) stages an "Experiment" conducted by inscrutable Mentors upon people drawn from many epochs, whose protagonist, Andrei Voronin, rises through the offices of the experimental city.

Whether the name of Duty's commander in *Shadow of Chernobyl*, General Voronin, is homage or coincidence cannot be established; the resonance between an experimental city administered by a Voronin and an experimental Zone policed by one is, at minimum, an affinity worth recording. Finally, *The Waves Extinguish the Wind* (1985–1986), the last novel of the Noon cycle, imagines the emergence from humanity of a posthuman branch, the Ludens, whose name, a Luden explains, plays at once on the Russian lyudi (people), on an anagram of nelyudi (the inhuman), and on Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938). The Strugatskys' final image of transcendence is named, in part, for play. The Ludens, moreover, experiment on human beings and alter their minds for their own ends, which is the C-Consciousness's exact practice. The C-Consciousness, which seeks to transcend humanity by fusing minds, is a Luden that failed; the player, who transcends nothing but plays, is the Luden the Zone actually receives.

1.6 The Censored Text as Exclusion Zone

Roadside Picnic was itself a zone. After its serialization, book publication was delayed for eight years, and the text that finally appeared was cut; Boris Strugatsky's *Comments on the Way Traversed* (*Комментарии к пройденному*) records the long negotiation with editors who objected to the coarseness of its language and the bleakness of its world, demanding excisions that the authors resisted and, as the memoir concedes, did not always defeat. The censored text has the structure of a territory under exclusion: a cordon of permitted words around a core of forbidden ones, traversed by readers who smuggled uncut versions in the manner of contraband. The Soviet reader of samizdat and tamizdat was already a stalker of texts, and the forbidden book was already an artifact, dangerous to possess and precious to exchange. Tatyana Tolstaya would make this literal in *The Slynx* (2000), where printed books surviving from before the Blast are contraband whose possession brings punishment. The Zone's first genealogy thus includes the condition of its own transmission: it was born in a culture where meaning itself was cordoned, and it carried that condition into every later form. The circle closed in 2000, when the brothers' collected works, including the memoir that tells this story, began to appear from a publisher named Stalker. In English the restored text arrived only in 2012, in Olena Bormashenko's translation from the authors' original.

From the Strugatskys, then, GSC inherits a vocabulary (Zone, stalker, artifact, the taxonomy of anomalies, the wish-granting centre, the sacrificial approach) and a moral problem (extraction, sacrifice, and the poverty of desire). What it does not inherit is the novel's suspension. The game cannot end on an utterance whose effect is withheld; it must show what the wish does. That obligation, which is the obligation of procedural form, drives everything that follows.



Chapter 2

The Tarkovskian Inflection: Kenosis, Threshold, and the Room

2.1 From Prospector to Holy Fool

Tarkovsky's *Stalker* converts the Zone from a site of extraction into a site of faith, and the stalker from a proletarian into a holy fool. The Strugatskys wrote the screenplay through numerous drafts, and with each the hard-bitten Red receded. The decisive change came out of catastrophe: after the first version's footage was ruined in processing, Tarkovsky rewrote the script, turning the Stalker from something like a petty criminal into a holy fool, and reshot the film in 1978. The film's theology of weakness was born of a material loss. The holy fool also wears a prisoner's shaved head. In camp slang, as Anne Applebaum records, the world beyond the barbed wire was called not freedom but the bolshaya zona, the big zone; Chris Marker drew the consequence for this film, in which asylum and freedom lie behind the wire, inside the Zone. In his place stands Alexander Kaidanovsky's Stalker: shaven-headed, frail, prone to weeping, a man who lives in poverty beside a railway line and whose sole vocation is to lead the desperate to the Room, which he himself may not use. He is the *yurodivy* of the Russian Orthodox tradition, the fool for Christ's sake whose apparent madness rebukes the wisdom of the world (1 Corinthians 4:10). Tarkovsky resisted allegorical decoding; he insisted, in substance, that the Zone symbolized nothing, that it was simply a zone, which is to say life itself. The insistence is theologically exact. In the kenotic tradition, the sacred does not symbolize; it is present in humility.

Kenosis, the self-emptying by which Christ "made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant" (Philippians 2:7, KJV), was identified by George Fedotov's *The Russian Religious Mind* (1946) and Nadejda Gorodetzky's *The Humiliated Christ in Modern Russian Thought* (1938) as a defining current of Russian spirituality. The Stalker is a kenotic figure: emptied of ambition, authority, and even of the power to profit from the Room he serves. His guidance is itself kenotic. He forbids

walking straight, insists that the Zone's paths shift according to the condition of those who walk them, and tests each route by throwing nuts tied with strips of cloth. That gesture, transmitted to GSC as the thrown bolt, is in Tarkovsky the liturgical act of a man who does not presume to know the way.

2.2 The Room and the Porcupine Principle

The film's central theological device is the Room, and its central doctrine is delivered through the story of Porcupine, the Stalker's teacher. Porcupine had led his own brother into the Meatgrinder, and he went to the Room to wish the brother back. He returned and became rich. Within a week he hanged himself. The Stalker draws the lesson: the Room grants not the wish one professes but the one that constitutes one, and Porcupine's death was the recognition of what his innermost desire had been. This is the **Porcupine principle**, and it is the single most consequential idea that GSC inherits. It makes the wish-granting centre an instrument not of satisfaction but of *diagnosis*.

Slavoj Žižek, in "The Thing from Inner Space" (1999) and in Sophie Fiennes's *The Pervert's Guide to Cinema* (2006), reads the Zone as a purely formal frame: the landscape is ordinary, and what transfigures it is the belief that it is not. Within the frame, the Room occupies the position of the Lacanian Thing, the place where the truth of desire, normally deferred by the symbolic order's endless substitutions, would be enacted in the Real. Lacan's distinction between *demand*, which is articulated, and *desire*, which insists beneath articulation, describes the Porcupine principle precisely: the Room ignores demand and answers desire. Jean-Luc Marion's distinction between idol and icon (*God Without Being*, 1982) sharpens the theological stakes. The idol is an invisible mirror that returns the gaze its own aim; the icon is the visible through which an invisible gaze regards the viewer. The Room, used, becomes an idol: it returns the wisher to himself. The Stalker's faith requires that it remain unentered, an icon whose power consists in its regard rather than its use.

2.3 Art, Science, and the Disassembled Bomb

The Stalker's two clients represent the two secular authorities of late-Soviet culture. The Writer is a cynic who suspects that art is vanity and fears that the Room would expose the baseness of his desires. The Professor is a physicist who has carried a bomb into the Zone to destroy the Room, reasoning that a place granting innermost wishes would become the instrument of fanatics and tyrants. At the threshold neither enters. The Writer refuses out of self-knowledge; the Professor, after a quarrel in which the Stalker pleads for the Room as the last hope of the hopeless, disassembles the bomb and throws its parts into the water. The film's climax is a non-act.

The gesture of throwing the bomb's pieces into the water acquires a further resonance in a Kyivan frame. The *Primary Chronicle* records that in 988, upon the conver-

sion of Rus', Prince Volodymyr ordered the idol of Perun dragged from its hill and thrown into the Dnieper. The founding act of Kyivan Christianity was an iconoclastic throw. The Professor reverses it: he throws away the instrument of iconoclasm in order to preserve the shrine. *Shadow of Chernobyl*, made in Kyiv, will reverse the reversal, completing the iconoclasm that the Professor abandons by having its protagonist destroy the false centre. Between the chronicle and the game, the film holds open the possibility that the sacred is best served by leaving it untouched. Art, science, and faith all arrive at the threshold; none crosses; and the Stalker, home again, weeps that no one believes any longer.

2.4 The Theology of Weakness

The film's theological core is a doctrine of weakness. In an interior monologue the Stalker prays that his companions may believe and may become helpless as children, adapting the seventy-sixth chapter of the *Tao Te Ching*: what lives is soft and supple, what dies is hard and stiff; the hard tree is felled; hardness is the companion of death and softness the companion of life. Tarkovsky's syncretism joins this Taoist teaching to the Pauline paradox that strength "is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9, KJV).

This doctrine sits in productive contradiction with the medium GSC chose. The first-person shooter is the genre of hardness: its progression systems reward heavier armour, stronger weapons, and greater lethality, and *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* culminates in exoskeletons and Gauss rifles. Yet the series repeatedly punishes hardness. Weight burdens movement, armour does not defeat anomalies, radiation penetrates the strongest suit, and the Emission kills the best-equipped stalker caught without shelter as surely as the rookie. The kenotic theology survives in the game not as a doctrine but as a recurring humiliation of power. Chapter 10 will argue that this contradiction reaches crisis at the series' climax, where the shooter must answer the Inquisitor with a gun.

2.5 The Miracle Without Witness

The film ends outside the Zone. In the Stalker's home, his daughter Monkey, unable to walk, recites a love poem of Fyodor Tyutchev and then, with her gaze alone, moves glasses across a table while a passing train shakes the room and the Ode to Joy of Beethoven's Ninth rises through the noise. The miracle is unwitnessed by the adults. Grace has migrated from the Room to the child of the Zone, from the shrine to the mutation, from the place of wishes to the place of suffering love, which the Stalker's wife, in her direct address to the camera, has just chosen over a safe and empty life.

Kierkegaard's knight of faith, in *Fear and Trembling*, is indistinguishable from a tax collector; the miracle of faith is invisible to the world. Tarkovsky's ending applies this principle to the Zone: its true gift is not the granting of wishes but the transform-

ation of the vulnerable, and it occurs where no one is looking. GSC inverts this sign while preserving its form. The series' telekinetic creatures, the poltergeist and the burer, possess Monkey's power, but in them it is terror rather than grace. The grace that Tarkovsky displaced into the child, the game displaces into the monster, and the player who learns to fear the burer's thrown debris has inherited Monkey's miracle as its negative.

2.6 The Production as Zone and the Constellation of 1979

The film's making replicated its subject. The first version, shot in 1977 by the cinematographer Georgy Rerberg, was ruined when Soviet laboratories mishandled an unfamiliar Kodak stock, and Tarkovsky reshot the film between June and November 1978 with Alexander Knyazhinsky. Location work took place near Tallinn, in and around an abandoned hydroelectric station on the Jägala river and adjacent industrial sites. The sound designer Vladimir Sharun later attributed the cancers that killed Anatoly Solonitsyn (1982), Tarkovsky himself (1986), and Larisa Tarkovskaya (1998) to toxic contamination at those locations, recalling a chemical plant upriver that poured poisonous liquids downstream. The claim cannot be verified, but its circulation is itself significant: the film about a lethal territory acquired the legend of a lethal shoot, and the boundary between the fictional Zone and real contamination began to dissolve before Chornobyl dissolved it entirely. Tallinn has since named a street after the film: Stalkeri käik, the Stalker's Path.

Stalker was released in 1979, a year whose constellation this thesis has already noted and which can now be specified. *The China Syndrome* opened on 16 March and the Three Mile Island reactor partially melted down on 28 March; the Strugatskys published *Beetle in the Anthill* with its sarcophagus; Ginzburg theorized the hunter's reading of traces; Lyotard declared the end of grand narratives; Hans Jonas proposed an ethics of responsibility for technological civilization; *Apocalypse Now* sent its protagonist upriver toward a man worshipped as a god; *Alien* sent its crew into a derelict containing the eggs of an incomprehensible life; and in December Soviet forces entered Afghanistan. The same year Prypiat, the atomic town beside the plant, was formally proclaimed a city; seven years later it was evacuated, and Tarkovsky's film became the frame through which the real Zone was seen. Liquidators, journalists, and later illegal visitors called themselves stalkers. Geoff Dyer's *Zona* (2012) testifies to the film's afterlife as a companion through which a life can be read.

From Tarkovsky, GSC inherits the bolt, the Porcupine principle, the threshold, and the conception of the Zone as a moral field responsive to those who enter it. What it cannot inherit is the refusal to enter. The film's highest act is abstention; the game's form is traversal. Where Tarkovsky leaves the Room closed, *Shadow of Chernobyl* must open it, and the question of what is found inside, and of what the finding does to the one who enters, is the question the rest of this thesis pursues.



Chapter 3

Chornobyl: The Zone of Alienation and the Accident as Revelation

3.1 26 April 1986

At 01:23 on 26 April 1986, during a test of turbine run-down in a simulated loss of power, Reactor No. 4 of the V. I. Lenin Nuclear Power Plant suffered a power excursion, a steam explosion, and a graphite fire that dispersed radionuclides across much of Europe. The reactor was an RBMK-1000, a graphite-moderated, water-cooled design whose instability at low power was compounded by procedural violations and by an institutional culture that treated such instability as a state secret. Prypiat, the plant's purpose-built city of some 49,000 inhabitants, was evacuated on 27 April, its residents told to pack for three days; none returned to live. A thirty-kilometre exclusion zone was declared, later expanded; hundreds of thousands were eventually resettled, and several hundred thousand liquidators were mobilized to contain the damage. The first international signal of the disaster came not from Moscow but from Sweden, where on 28 April workers at the Forsmark plant set off radiation alarms with their own shoes.

The human cost began that night. Two plant workers died from the explosion, one at once and one within hours. Of the 134 plant staff and emergency workers whose acute radiation sickness was confirmed, 28 died within four months, among them firefighters and operators who had worked beside the ruined reactor; nineteen more died of various causes by 2004. The longer toll remains contested. The UN-led Chernobyl Forum (2005) projected about 4,000 eventual deaths among the most heavily exposed populations, while other assessments, and historians such as Kate Brown, argue that the official accounting has undercounted the harm. Among those who were children or adolescents in 1986, nearly 20,000 thyroid cancers were diagnosed between 1991 and 2015, and UNSCEAR attributes roughly a quarter of them, some 5,000, to radioactive iodine, carried largely in milk. The dead of Chornobyl are

themselves an anomaly in Kuhn's sense: each paradigm of measurement counts them differently.

Responsibility was assigned selectively, and the place of judgment is itself instructive. In July 1987 six men were tried in a temporary courtroom in the House of Culture in the town of Chornobyl, inside the Zone, because Soviet law required that a trial be held near the scene of the crime. The plant's director, Viktor Bryukhanov, its chief engineer, Nikolai Fomin, and his deputy, Anatoly Dyatlov, received ten years each; three others received shorter terms; the verdict laid the blame on the plant's management and operators. The International Atomic Energy Agency's safety advisory group broadly accepted that account in its first report (INSAG-1, 1986), but its revised report (INSAG-7, 1992) placed the main cause in the reactor's design, including a control-rod configuration that briefly increased reactivity at the start of an emergency shutdown, an effect already reported at the Ignalina plant in 1983 and never clearly disclosed in the operating documentation. Dyatlov, released early in failing health, spent his last years arguing that even the revised verdict was wrong. The Zone was a tribunal before it was a game: the first court to sit in it convicted the men at the controls while the reactor's designers stood outside the dock, and later inquiries have contested its verdict ever since.

By November 1986 the ruined reactor had been enclosed in the Shelter Object, universally called the Sarcophagus; in November 2016 the New Safe Confinement, the largest movable land structure ever built, was slid over it. The popular name carries an etymology the series exploits without stating. Greek *sarkophagos* means "flesh-eating," after a limestone that Pliny the Elder reported would consume a corpse within weeks. Soviet modernity was punctuated by sarcophagi: the glass coffin of Lenin's Mausoleum, preserved in expectation of a scientific resurrection; the Wanderers' sarcophagus of the Strugatskys' *Beetle in the Anthill*; and the concrete Sarcophagus of Chornobyl, beneath which lies the corium mass known as the Elephant's Foot. *Shadow of Chernobyl* places its god inside the last of these. The demiurge of the Zone dwells in a flesh-eating stone.

3.2 *Zona otchuzhdeniya*: Alienation Made Territory

The territory's official name is the most philosophically charged toponym of the late twentieth century. Russian *зона отчуждения*, Ukrainian *зона відчуження*, is rendered in English both as "exclusion zone" and as "zone of alienation." The second rendering is exact. *Отчуждение* is the standard Russian translation of Marx's *Entfremdung* in the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*, where alienated labour (*отчуждённый труд*) is labour whose product confronts the producer as an alien power, independent of him and hostile to him. The Chornobyl Zone is that confrontation made topographical. The most advanced energy complex of a workers' state, together with the model city built for its workers, turned against its makers as a

territory they could neither inhabit nor understand. The Soviet state claimed to have abolished alienation by abolishing private property. Chornobyl demonstrated that alienation persisted at the level of the technical apparatus itself, that the product of collective labour could become alien without ever becoming private.

The word carries two further senses. In juridical Russian, *отчуждение* denotes the alienation of property, its transfer or expropriation: the land was alienated from its inhabitants by administrative act. In psychological usage it denotes estrangement. The Zone is alienated in all three senses at once: as product turned against producer, as property withdrawn from use, and as place estranged from meaning. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) opens with Sputnik and with the inscription on the obelisk of a Russian scientist, Konstantin Tsiolkovsky, declaring that humanity would not remain bound to the earth forever; Arendt diagnosed "earth alienation" as the signature of the modern age. Her prologue also binds together the two dreams that the C-Consciousness would later fuse: the wish to escape the earth and the hope of breeding superior human beings in the laboratory, both for her expressions of a single rebellion against human existence as it has been given. Another Russian scientist saw the other face of the same century. Vernadsky, whose noosphere Chapter 4 follows from its Kyivan beginnings, founded the Radium Institute in 1922 and in the same year warned that humanity would soon hold atomic energy in its hands, asking whether it would turn that force to good or to self-destruction, and whether it had grown mature enough to use the power that science must inevitably give it. It is the peirastic question in its first nuclear form. The Zone realizes earth alienation in inverted form. It is not humanity that leaves the earth but a piece of the earth that expels humanity. The Cosmist dream of leaving the cradle meets a cradle that can no longer be inhabited.

3.3 Invisible Risk and the Prosthetic Sense

Ulrich Beck's *Risikogesellschaft* appeared in 1986, its preface written under the immediate impression of Chornobyl. Beck argued that the risks of reflexive modernity are imperceptible to the unaided senses, that they require the "sensory organs" of science (theories, instruments, measurements) to become visible at all, and that they abolish the distinction between those exposed and those outside. *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* translates this condition into a phenomenology of play. The crackle of the Geiger counter and the climbing radiation indicator are prosthetic senses through which the player perceives what cannot be seen; the anomaly detector's beeping is another. The player's body is perpetually mediated by instruments that render invisible danger audible, and the experience of the Zone is the experience of depending on such instruments while knowing they are partial.

The temporal scale of this danger exceeds every human institution. Caesium-137 has a half-life of about thirty years; plutonium-239, of about twenty-four thousand.

Timothy Morton's *Hyperobjects* (2013) names such entities viscous, nonlocal, and temporally undulating, massively distributed in time and space relative to human perception. The Zone is the local face of a hyperobject: a bounded territory that is the visible edge of an invisible, centuries-long event. Günther Anders, in *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956), had named the "Promethean gap" between what humanity can produce and what it can imagine or feel, and the "Promethean shame" of humans before the perfection of their products. The Zone is the Promethean gap given borders. Paul Virilio's dictum that to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck, extended in *The Original Accident* (2005) to nuclear power, and Charles Perrow's *Normal Accidents* (1984), which showed that complex and tightly coupled systems make catastrophe statistically ordinary, together establish the accident not as an aberration of modernity but as its hidden face. To this must be added what the historian of science Robert Proctor has called agnotology, the cultural production of ignorance: the Soviet state surrounded the physical Zone with a cordon of silence. Prypiat was not evacuated until the afternoon of 27 April, some thirty-six hours after the explosion; the first public acknowledgment, a four-sentence statement of the USSR Council of Ministers, was read on the evening television news of 28 April, after the Swedish alarms had made silence untenable. That same day the republic's leaders, Volodymyr Shcherbytsky among them, received hydrometeorological reports of contamination across Ukraine; and on 1 May the May Day demonstration in Kyiv went ahead, more than 120,000 marchers with schoolchildren among them, before the Ukrainian party leadership, while radiation levels in the city were rising. The Zone of knowledge was excluded before the Zone of land, and the exclusion was decided by identifiable authorities rather than suffered as an accident of communication.

3.4 Wormwood

Within months of the disaster a scriptural reading circulated; its earliest known appearance in the Western press is a New York Times report of 26 July 1986. "And the third angel sounded, and there fell a great star from heaven, burning as it were a lamp, and it fell upon the third part of the rivers, and upon the fountains of waters; and the name of the star is called Wormwood: and the third part of the waters became wormwood; and many men died of the waters, because they were made bitter" (Revelation 8:10–11, KJV). The Ukrainian *чорнобиль* names *Artemisia vulgaris*, mugwort, whereas the Russian Synodal Bible renders the star as *полынь*, *Artemisia absinthium*, true wormwood. The identification of Chornobyl with Wormwood therefore rests on generic kinship rather than identity: it is an exegesis by near-synonym. The kinship is doubled, since the plant of the Apocalypse was most likely neither species but a third, Artemisia judaica, while Ukrainian usage sometimes treats polyn and chornobyl as synonyms. Yet it was reported widely, it shaped the event's reception in East and West alike, and Mary Mycio adopted it for the title of her natural his-

tory of the Zone, *Wormwood Forest* (2005). The exegesis has since become architecture: since the twenty-fifth anniversary in 2011, a Wormwood Star memorial complex in the town of Chornobyl has displayed a statue of the trumpeting third angel.

The exegetical structure matters more than its philology. The Wormwood reading gave the catastrophe a retroactive prophecy: the event had always already been foretold. The same structure governs the Zone's cultural transmission, in which Tarkovsky's film is retrospectively read as prophecy and the Strugatskys' sarcophagus as premonition. The Zone is experienced as a text written in advance of its occurrence. *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* inherits this hermeneutic and builds it into its premise: the second disaster of 2006 that creates the game's Zone is presented as the fulfilment of the first, and the player enters a world whose catastrophe has already been interpreted before it is understood.

3.5 From the Woodpecker to the Brain Scorcher

Several kilometres from the plant stood Chernobyl-2, a secret military town serving the Duga over-the-horizon radar, a colossal antenna array designed to detect missile launches; Chernobyl-2 held its receivers, while the transmitters stood at a separate site, Liubech-1. From July 1976 to December 1989 the radar's signal, a repetitive tapping that radio amateurs called the Russian Woodpecker, disrupted shortwave broadcasts across the world and fuelled speculation that the Soviets were experimenting with weather control or mind control. *Shadow of Chernobyl* literalizes the conspiracy. The array becomes the Brain Scorcher, a psychotronic emitter that burns out the minds of those who approach the Zone's north and guards the path to its centre; the protagonist must shut it down to proceed. A real instrument of the military-scientific complex is converted into a weapon against consciousness. The conversion is also an inversion: the array at Chernobyl-2 only listened, and the game turns an instrument for receiving into one that broadcasts into minds.

The conversion draws on a broader late-Soviet imaginary. Soviet laboratories had investigated telepathy and suggestion since the work of Leonid Vasiliev in the 1920s, and Cold War rumour on both sides spoke of psychotronic weapons. In 1989, as the state's ideological authority dissolved, the psychotherapist Anatoly Kashpirovsky conducted televised sessions of mass hypnosis, and the healer Allan Chumak claimed to charge water and creams that viewers set before their television screens. Kashpirovsky worked from Kyiv, where he had headed the republic's Centre of Psychotherapy since 1988, and his six séances on Central Television began on 9 October 1989. There are indications, Bernice Glatzer Rosenthal writes, that the Party officials who ran state television hoped the séances would serve as a "grand diversion" from the collapsing economy. In the autumn of 1989, as the Woodpecker was about to fall silent, the state's own transmitters were broadcasting into minds. The series condenses this occult boom into a coherent technology of domination: the Brain Scorch-

er, the Miracle Machine at Yantar, the psychic assaults of controllers, the Monolith's emitters. Each is a machine for acting directly upon minds, and each is a corrupted instrument of what Chapter 4 will identify as the noospheric project.

3.6 The Cancelled Future

Prypiat was an *atomgrad*, one of the Soviet atomic cities built as showcases of planned futurity, home to 49,360 people when it was evacuated. Its population was young, its architecture modernist, its amenities exemplary: the Palace of Culture Energetik, the Hotel Polissya, a stadium, a swimming pool, and an amusement park whose Ferris wheel was due to open on 1 May 1986. Whether the wheel ever turned for the public is disputed: several accounts report that the park was opened briefly on 27 April, before the evacuation was announced, while others say it never opened at all. If those accounts are right, the city's last festival was a diversion staged under the fallout. The ground beneath the wheel remains among the most contaminated in the city. It stands in the series' Pripyat, as in the real city, as the emblem of a future built, inhabited, and cancelled within a day.

Mark Fisher's *Ghosts of My Life* (2014), developing Franco "Bifo" Berardi's phrase "the slow cancellation of the future," defined hauntology as the persistence of futures that failed to arrive. Prypiat is hauntology's literal capital, and its cancellation was not slow but instantaneous. Jacques Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993), written after the Soviet collapse, asked what it means to inherit a spectre; the Zone is where the spectre took up residence, among May Day placards and classroom slogans. Svetlana Boym's *The Future of Nostalgia* (2001) distinguished restorative nostalgia, which seeks to rebuild the lost home, from reflective nostalgia, which dwells on longing and loss; the series' material culture of Soviet lamps, posters, and tinned stew solicits the reflective kind, and its global audience's attachment to a Soviet world it never knew is a nostalgia without memory. Mikhail Gorbachev, writing on the twentieth anniversary in 2006, suggested that Chornobyl, more even than his own reforms, may have been the true cause of the Soviet Union's collapse five years later. If so, the Zone is the grave of the Soviet future, and every stalker who walks through Prypiat walks across it.

3.7 Real Stalkers, Occupied Zone

The games produced their own reality. A subculture of illegal trekkers, many inspired by the series, began entering the exclusion zone on foot and calling themselves stalkers. Markiyan Kamysh, the son of a liquidator, chronicled their nocturnal crossings, abandoned villages, and Prypiat rooftops in a book first published in Ukrainian in 2015 and in English in 2022 as *Stalking the Atomic City*. He calls what he seeks there "true alienation," and among his names for himself is tracker, the sledopyt of Chapter 6: the official name of the territory has become the stalker's own vocabulary of desire.

Official tourism grew alongside, accelerated by HBO's *Chernobyl* (2019), and a presidential decree of July 2019 committed the state to developing the Zone as a destination. Volodymyr Zelensky signed it on the day he inaugurated the New Safe Confinement, describing the territory as a unique place where nature revives after a man-made catastrophe: the state rebranded its zone of alienation in the ceremony that inaugurated the structure sealing the reactor. Some 150 elderly residents, self-settlers who had returned to their villages in defiance of the authorities, still lived there, the real Zone's own non-faction. Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) described a precession of simulacra in which the model precedes the real; here the precession is literal. Visitors arrive with the game's map in their heads, and the real Zone is experienced as a copy of its simulation. The circuit runs from novel to film to catastrophe to game to subculture to tourism, and at each stage the copy reshapes the original.

The Zone's ecology compounds the paradox. In the absence of humans, wolves, boar, elk, and the Przewalski's horses brought in from 1998 have proliferated, and the territory has been celebrated as an inadvertent wilderness. The horses were introduced to stand in for the tarpan, the region's extinct wild horse; the programme was soon halted, but the animals stayed and multiplied, an abandoned experiment whose subjects outlived it, like the mutants of the games' laboratories. Kate Brown's *Manual for Survival* (2019) contests this pastoral, documenting health effects long minimized by Soviet and international agencies. Adriana Petryna's *Life Exposed* (2002) showed how post-Soviet Ukrainians constituted a "biological citizenship," claiming state support on the basis of radiation-damaged bodies. The stalker is the biological citizen's inverse: one who seeks exposure rather than compensation, and converts damage into livelihood.

On 24 February 2022, the first day of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, Russian forces entered the Zone from Belarus, seized the plant, and kept its operating staff at their posts under armed guard, without rotation, for nearly four weeks, conditions Ukrainian officials described as hostage-taking. Russian armour churned through the Red Forest, among the most contaminated ground in the Zone, raising radioactive dust without any dosimetric control, and units dug trenches and fortifications there before withdrawing at the end of March. Energoatom, Ukraine's state nuclear operator, reported the entrenchment, later documented in drone footage, and claimed that soldiers had received significant doses; the IAEA could not confirm the claim. As they withdrew, Ukraine's defence ministry reported, the occupiers looted laboratory equipment and took with them the Ukrainian National Guard troops captured at the plant. On the night of 14 February 2025 a drone with a high-explosive warhead struck the New Safe Confinement, piercing its roof and starting fires in its cladding that took weeks to extinguish. Ukraine attributed the strike to a Russian attack drone; the Kremlin denied responsibility. In December 2025 the International Atomic Energy Agency reported that the structure had lost its primary safety func-

tions, including its capacity to confine radioactive material, although its load-bearing frame and monitoring systems were undamaged and radiation levels remained normal. The Zone ceased to be a museum of past catastrophe and became a front of present war. The fiction's military cordons, bandit economies, and fanatics acquired an unbearable referent, and the series' sequel was completed under these conditions. Chornobyl thus gives *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* not only its topography (Cordon, Red Forest, Radar, Pripyat, the plant) and its frozen time, but the meaning of its name. The Zone is alienation, and the history of its alienation did not end in 1986.



Chapter 4

The Noosphere and the Cosmist Inheritance

4.1 Vernadsky, Le Roy, Teilhard

The demiurge of *Shadow of Chernobyl* speaks the language of the noosphere, and that language has a Kyivan origin. Vladimir Vernadsky (1863–1945), mineralogist and founder of biogeochemistry, was in 1918 the first president of the Ukrainian Academy of Sciences in Kyiv. His *Biosphere* (1926) argued that living matter is a geological force, transforming the planet's chemistry on the scale of mountains and oceans. During lectures at the Sorbonne in 1922–1923 Vernadsky entered into conversation with the philosopher Édouard Le Roy and the Jesuit palaeontologist Pierre Teilhard de Chardin, and in 1927 Le Roy became the first to publish the term *noosphere* for the envelope of thought that, in their shared view, was succeeding the biosphere as the decisive planetary layer. Teilhard had already used the word in his own writings of the 1920s, and priority remains disputed: the concept of planetary mind has no single author, having been born, fittingly, of a conversation among three. Vernadsky's own development of the concept, in essays culminating in "Some Words about the Noosphere" (1944), remained naturalist: the noosphere is the stage at which scientific thought and organized human labour become a geological power, so that reason must assume responsibility for the planet it is reshaping.

Teilhard's version, elaborated in *The Phenomenon of Man* (written 1938–1940, published 1955), was eschatological. Evolution, he argued, proceeds by increasing complexity and consciousness, and the noosphere is converging toward an Omega Point, a hyper-personal unification of consciousness that he identified with the cosmic Christ. Two noospheres thus descend from the Parisian conversation: Vernadsky's, a sphere of planetary reason accountable to science, and Teilhard's, a sphere of converging spirit destined for transcendence. The C-Consciousness fuses them. It is a scientific project, in Vernadsky's idiom, aimed at a mystical convergence, in Teilhard's, and it fails at both. In the series' cosmology the noosphere is a planetary field

of collective mind; the C-Consciousness's attempt to intervene in it ruptured it, and the Zone is the result. The Zone is therefore a wound in the noosphere, a scar on planetary consciousness, and it is not incidental that the protagonist of the prequel is called Scar.

4.2 The Common Task: Fyodorov, Tsiolkovsky, Bogdanov

The noosphere is one tributary of a larger current that Western scholarship since the 1990s, and Boris Groys's anthology *Russian Cosmism* (2018), have made visible. Its founder, Nikolai Fyodorov (1829–1903), a librarian at the Rumyantsev Museum admired by Dostoevsky, Tolstoy, and Solovyov, taught in the posthumously compiled *Philosophy of the Common Task* (1906–1913) that humanity's supreme duty is the resurrection of all its ancestors through science, the regulation of nature, and the colonization of space to house the resurrected. Konstantin Tsiolkovsky (1857–1935), the theorist of rocketry, combined this programme with a panpsychist monism in which every atom is a sentient unit of a living universe. Alexander Bogdanov (1873–1928), Lenin's Bolshevik rival and author of the Martian utopia *Red Star* (1908), developed *Tektology* as a universal science of organization and sought "physiological collectivism" through the mutual exchange of blood; he founded the Institute for Blood Transfusion in 1926 and died in April 1928 after an exchange transfusion with a student suffering from malaria and tuberculosis. Leonid Krasin wrote to his wife that Bogdanov seemed seven, even ten, years younger after one of the operations, and Lenin's sister Maria Ulyanova volunteered for the experiments. The C-Consciousness, seven scientists fused into a single mind, is physiological collectivism completed.

Each of these figures bequeaths a component of the C-Consciousness. From Fyodorov comes immortality as a scientific task, and with it the series' grotesque inversions: revenants that return without spirit, zombies that wander without purpose, and the false ending in which the wish for immortality turns the wisher into a metal statue, neither living nor dead. From Tsiolkovsky comes the intuition that matter is alive and willing, which the Zone confirms in the worst possible sense: anomalies that seem to wait, Emissions that seem to answer, a territory of which stalkers say that it *wants*. From Bogdanov comes the fusion of individuals into a collective organism, the dissolution of the ego into an organized whole. Leonid Krasin, influenced by Fyodorov, hoped that Lenin's preserved body might one day be scientifically revived; the glass coffin of the Mausoleum is Cosmism's most public monument. The crystalline Monolith venerated in the Sarcophagus by fanatics who have surrendered their wills is its parody: a relic before which bodies kneel, preserved by an intelligence that promises transcendence and delivers stasis.

4.3 Perfectibility and Its Satirists

Cosmism's political counterpart was the project of remaking human nature. In the closing pages of *Literature and Revolution* (1924), Trotsky prophesied that man would become immeasurably stronger, wiser, and subtler, that his body would become harmonized and his voice musical, and that the average human type would rise to the level of an Aristotle, a Goethe, or a Marx. The "New Soviet Man" was the anthropological promise of the revolution. The C-Consciousness is its late, technocratic descendant: it seeks perfectibility not through social revolution but through direct intervention in the collective psyche, excising humanity's aggression and malice at their noospheric source.

The great satirists of the perfectibility project had already imagined this operation. In Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–1921), the One State's Great Operation cauterizes the brain's centre of fantasy with X-rays, so that citizens, freed of imagination, may be perfectly happy; the Benefactor presides over a glass city sealed from wild nature by the Green Wall. The C-Consciousness's intervention is the Great Operation scaled to the species. The Zone's cordon is the Green Wall inverted: Zamyatin's wall keeps nature out of the rational city, whereas the Cordon keeps the irrational Zone out of the rational world, and in both cases what lies beyond the wall is where freedom survives. Andrei Platonov's *The Foundation Pit* (written 1929–1930) follows workers excavating the foundation of an "all-proletarian home" that will shelter everyone; the pit deepens into a grave, and a child is buried in its wall. Its hero Voshchev wanders in search of "the meaning of general existence." Platonov wrote the novel in the first winter of forced collectivization, and in it the peasants the state has declared kulaks, class enemies, are set adrift downriver on a raft. In Soviet Ukraine the same policy culminated in the famine of 1932–1933, the Holodomor, produced by the Soviet leadership under Stalin through grain-requisition quotas, the confiscation of food, the blacklisting of villages, and a secret January 1933 directive, signed by Stalin, that barred starving peasants from leaving Ukraine and the Kuban; an estimated 3.5 to 5 million people died. Ukraine and, since 2022, a growing number of parliaments recognize it as genocide, while historians continue to debate whether it meets the legal definition. The Plan had drawn its first zone of mass death in Ukraine half a century before Chornobyl. The Zone is the Foundation Pit completed: the foundation of a planned future that became a tomb, and the stalker is Voshchev's heir, searching the debris of the plan for a meaning the plan did not contain.

4.4 The Psychotronic Imaginary

The C-Consciousness's target is not the individual mind but what the series' idiom treats as a collective substrate, and here a third current joins Vernadsky and Fyodorov: Carl Gustav Jung's collective unconscious, the layer of inherited archetypes

beneath personal experience. The project presupposes that such a layer exists, that it is accessible through the noosphere, and that it can be edited. The consequence, on a reading this thesis proposes, is that the rupture spilled the collective unconscious into the biosphere. Lem's *Solaris* materialized individual guilt as visitors; the Zone materializes collective archetypes as fauna. The bloodsucker is the East Slavic *upyr* given flesh; the controller is the evil eye given a body; the poltergeist is the domestic spirit turned malign. Chapter 7 develops this teratology. Its premise is that the Zone's monsters are not random mutations but the archetypal fears of a culture, released by a failed attempt to purge them.

The instruments of the attempt belong to the psychotronic imaginary traced in Chapter 3: the Soviet laboratories of suggestion, the Cold War rumours of mind weapons, the televised hypnotists of 1989. The C-Consciousness acts through machines that act upon consciousness directly, bypassing persuasion. Its relation to humanity is therefore not political but technical, and its failure is the failure of a politics that sought to dispense with politics by operating directly on the substrate of human will.

4.5 Semiosphere and Explosion

The noosphere has a semiotic double. Yuri Lotman, founder with others of the Tartu–Moscow school, introduced the *semiosphere* in 1984 explicitly on the model of Vernadsky's biosphere: the semiotic space outside which meaning cannot exist, organized into a core of stable codes and a periphery where codes meet, collide, and generate new meaning through acts of translation at the boundary. The Zone is a boundary region of the late-Soviet and post-Soviet semiosphere. Science, Orthodoxy, folklore, market, military, and criminal argot converge there and fail to translate into one another, and the failure is productive: it generates the Zone's folk taxonomy, its legends, its jokes, and its liturgies.

Lotman's last book, *Culture and Explosion* (1992), written as the Soviet Union disintegrated, distinguished gradual historical processes from explosions, moments of unpredictability at which many futures become possible and which are afterwards narrated as though they had been inevitable. Chornobyl was an explosion in both senses. The Zone, with its recurrent Emissions, is a permanent explosion: a space that refuses to settle into gradual process and in which the future remains unpredictable at every moment. Where the noosphere promised a planetary reason that would make history controllable, the semiosphere's explosion names what escapes control, and the Zone is the territory of that escape.

4.6 The C-Consciousness as Late-Cosmist *Gesamtkunstwerk*

Boris Groys's *Gesamtkunstwerk Stalin* (1988) argued that Stalinism realized the avant-garde's ambition to transform life itself into a total work of art, with the state as

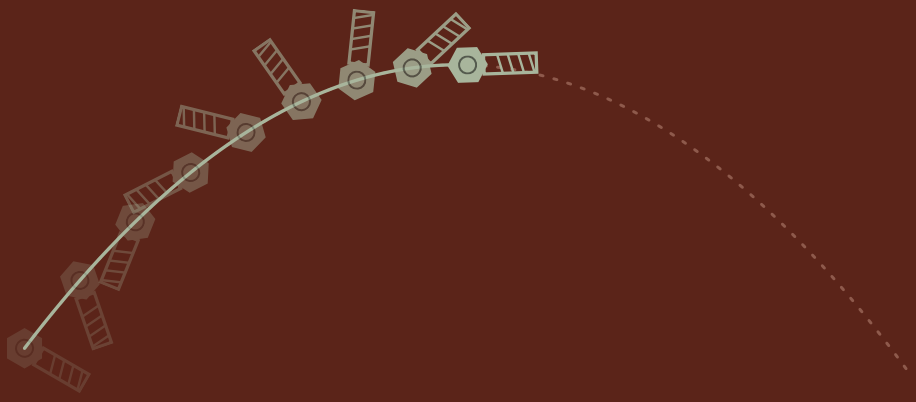
artist and the population as material. The C-Consciousness is the last avatar of this ambition: a cabal of scientists who aimed to make the human species their artwork by editing its collective mind, with the noosphere as canvas. Its composition can now be stated. It is Vernadsky's planetary reason, Teilhard's converging spirit, Fyodorov's immortality, Bogdanov's collective fusion, Trotsky's perfectibility, Jung's collective unconscious, and the Soviet psychotronic apparatus, condensed into a single intelligence hidden at the centre of a flesh-eating stone.

The series' critique of this composite is structural rather than satirical. All its components share a premise: that human nature can be engineered from above by those who possess total knowledge. The Zone is what that premise produces. Yet the critique is not a repudiation of the longing that animated Cosmism. The stalker's search for the meaning of the Zone, the reverence with which the series renders its landscapes, and the persistence of a desire for some cosmic significance in the debris are themselves Cosmist in temper. The series indicts the engineering, not the longing. What it proposes in place of the Plan is not a smaller ambition but a different relation to the unknown: not the total knowledge of the demiurge but the partial, risked knowledge of the thrown bolt.

Part

II

Exegesis of the Zone



Part II moves from inheritance to structure. It reads the Zone as a space, an epistemology, a material culture, a polity, a theology, and a story about a self, attending throughout to how each dimension is encoded in mechanics as well as narrative.



Chapter 5

Topologies: Katabasis, Heterotopia, Exception

5.1 Concentric Descent

The Zone of *Shadow of Chernobyl* is organized as a descent toward a centre, and its topology is infernal. The player enters from the south at the Cordon, past a military checkpoint, into the Rookie Village and the bunker of the trader Sidorovich. The route proceeds north through the Garbage, a graveyard of contaminated vehicles; past the research institute at Agroprom and the bandit stronghold of the Dark Valley; through the Duty-held Rostok factory and its Bar; to the scientists' bunker at Yantar, the Freedom base at the Army Warehouses, the Red Forest, the Radar and its Brain Scorcher, Pripyat, and finally the power plant and the Sarcophagus. Radiation intensifies, anomalies densify, and enemies harden along this axis, from rookies and bandits to the masked fanatics of the Monolith. The gradient is concentric.

The structure is Dante's. The *Inferno* narrows through circles of increasing gravity to Cocytus, where Satan, frozen at the centre, is the inverse of the God from whom all things proceed. At the centre of the Zone sits the Wish Granter, a false god in a crystalline body. Dante's descent is halted at the walls of Dis until a heavenly messenger opens the gate; the Brain Scorcher is the Zone's wall of Dis, but no messenger comes, and the stalker must disable it himself. The Sumerian *Descent of Inanna* supplies a further pattern: the goddess passes seven gates of the underworld and at each is stripped of an emblem of power until she stands naked before Ereshkigal. The stalker's progress is likewise a stripping, of companions, of illusions about the Zone, and finally of the identity he thought he possessed.

Vladimir Propp's *Historical Roots of the Wondertale* (1946) interpreted the East Slavic tale's journey to the "thrice-ninth kingdom" as the memory of initiation rites, in which the novice crossed a forest, passed the hut of Baba Yaga as guardian of the threshold of death, and returned transformed. The Red Forest is the Zone's initiatory

forest, its pines killed red by radiation, and beyond it lies the kingdom of the dead. Superimposed on this horizontal descent is a vertical one. The X-laboratories (X18 beneath the Dark Valley, X16 beneath Yantar, X10 beneath the Radar) take the player underground into the hidden basements of Soviet science, where, in the series' fiction, scientists experimented on human subjects as well as animals, producing the mutants and psychic weapons that now populate the Zone. Each laboratory is a cave in Plato's sense, a place of artificial light and manipulated images, and the Republic's own frame is katabatic: it opens with Socrates saying that he went down (*katebēn*) to the Piraeus, and its allegory culminates in the injunction that the philosopher, having ascended, must go down again (*katabateon*, 520c). The Zone's katabasis is double, horizontal and vertical, and its obligation to return is a theme to which Chapter 14 returns.

5.2 The Zone as Heterotopia

Michel Foucault's lecture "Of Other Spaces" (delivered 1967, published 1984) defined heterotopias as real places that function as counter-sites, in which the other real sites of a culture are simultaneously represented, contested, and inverted. Foucault proposed six principles, and the Zone satisfies each with unusual completeness.

First, every culture constitutes heterotopias, of crisis or of deviation; the Zone is a heterotopia of deviation, the place to which the deviant gravitate: stalkers, bandits, deserters, fanatics. Second, a society can make an existing heterotopia function differently over time; the Zone has been industrial showcase, exclusion territory, scientific reserve, tourist destination, and battlefield. Third, a heterotopia juxtaposes in a single real place several incompatible spaces; the Zone does so literally, in spatial anomalies that fold distance, in the looping streets of *Clear Sky*'s Limansk, and in the recursive passage to *Call of Pripyat*'s Oasis, while also layering Soviet past, post-Soviet present, and the noospheric or alien. Fourth, heterotopias are linked to slices of time, heterochronies; the Zone joins the accumulating time of the museum, in a Prypiat arrested in 1986, to the cyclical time of the festival, in the recurrence of the Emission. Fifth, heterotopias presuppose a system of opening and closing, entered by compulsion or by rites of purification; the Zone is entered through bribed checkpoints and initiatory tasks, and its centre is sealed by the Brain Scorcher and by a door that opens only to a decoder. Sixth, a heterotopia functions in relation to all remaining space, either as illusion, exposing ordinary space as more illusory still, or as compensation, a space as perfect as ours is disordered. The Zone performs both functions inversely: a space as perfectly disordered as the outer world pretends to be ordered, whose dangers expose the illusoriness of the safety outside.

Foucault closed his lecture with the ship as "the heterotopia par excellence" and with an image of civilizations without boats in which espionage replaces adventure

and the police replace pirates. That sentence will prove prophetic of *Call of Pripyat*, whose hub is a beached ship and whose protagonist is a police spy (Chapter 12).

5.3 Ban, Camp, Abandonment

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) distinguished *zoē*, bare biological life, from *bios*, qualified political life, and identified in the archaic figure of the *homo sacer* the one who may be killed with impunity but not sacrificed. The sovereign is the one who decides on the exception, and the camp is the space opened when the exception becomes the rule, which Agamben called the hidden *nomos* of modernity. The relation of exception is a relation of ban; and, following Jean-Luc Nancy's essay "L'être abandonné" (1983), Agamben insisted that the banned is not simply expelled but *abandoned*, exposed at the threshold where law withdraws its protection while retaining its force.

The Zone is a camp in Agamben's sense. At the Cordon, soldiers fire on trespassers; stalkers are killable without crime, and the zombified, life reduced to biological persistence without speech or purpose, are bare life incarnate. The Russian word *zona* had long named, in the argot of their inmates, the forced-labour camps of the Gulag, run by the Soviet secret police, through which some eighteen million people passed between 1930 and 1953 and of whom, on the emerging scholarly consensus, roughly 1.5 to 1.7 million died in the camps or soon after release, and the Zone's social codes descend from the camp's: bandits speak the criminal cant called *fenya*, and the protagonist's identity is first legible as a tattoo, the camp's archive written on skin. Varlam Shalamov's *Kolyma Tales* recorded the camp as the place where everything human is stripped away, and the tales shared the zone's exclusion: written between 1954 and 1973, they appeared in Russian only abroad, in 1978, with a note disclaiming the author's consent in order to protect him, and in the USSR only in 1989; Solzhenitsyn's *Gulag Archipelago* (1973) mapped a scattered nation of zones. The Chornobyl Zone is an island of that archipelago that outlived the state that made it. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003), defining sovereignty as the power to dictate who may live and who must die, completes the analysis: the Cordon is a necropolitical frontier, and the series' military is its instrument.

The etymology of *abandon* closes the circle with the lexicon of throwing. To abandon is to place *à bandon*, under the ban; to be *заброшенный* or *покинутий* is to be thrown away. In the Zone, juridical abandonment and ballistic abandonment coincide: the territory is at once banned and discarded, and those who enter it accept both conditions.

5.4 Smooth Space and the Stalker-Nomad

In *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari distinguished striated space, metric, gridded, sedentary, and characteristic of the State, from smooth

space, vectorial, haptic, occupied by intensities rather than measured by coordinates, and characteristic of the nomad. The Zone is smooth space in its purest ludic form. Anomalies make metric navigation lethal; the stalker moves by local, haptic signs (the shimmer of distorted air, the detector's accelerating tone, the flight of the bolt); paths valid yesterday are invalid today. Duty and the military attempt to striate the Zone with checkpoints, patrols, and fortified bases; Freedom presents itself as a nomadic war machine but holds a base of its own. The loner stalker is the true nomad, moving from campfire to campfire without territory. The Emission, which redistributes anomalies, periodically re-smooths every space that the factions have striated, and in this respect the Zone itself is the ultimate war machine, exterior to every State that claims it.

5.5 Threshold and Liminality

Arnold van Gennep's *Rites of Passage* (1909) divided ritual transition into separation, margin, and aggregation; Victor Turner's *The Ritual Process* (1969) developed the marginal phase into a theory of liminality, the condition of being betwixt and between, and of *communitas*, the spontaneous, egalitarian bond among those who share it. The Cordon is a limen, and the opening of *Shadow of Chernobyl* is a rite of passage: the newcomer receives tasks from Sidorovich, retrieves a first artifact, throws a first bolt, and is incorporated into the fraternity of stalkers. But the Zone never completes the rite. There is no aggregation back into ordinary society; the stalker remains permanently liminal, and the communitas of the campfire is the social form of a margin that has become a way of life.

Mikhail Bakhtin's essay on the chronotope (written 1937–1938) identified in Dostoevsky a chronotope of the threshold, where time is compressed into instants of crisis and decision, on staircases, landings, and doorways. The Zone is a total threshold-chronotope. Every step may be decisive; every unexplored metre is a doorway; and time is measured not in days but in the interval between one danger and the next.

5.6 The Emission as Sacred Time

Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) and *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) argued that archaic religion experiences sacred time as cyclical, reactualized through rites that repeat the cosmogony: at the New Year the world returns to chaos and is created anew. The Emission, rendered narratively in *Shadow of Chernobyl* and as a systemic event in *Clear Sky* and *Call of Pripyat*, is this rite in technological form. The sky reddens, sirens sound, and every unsheltered being dies; corpses rise; anomalies are redistributed; new artifacts appear. The Zone returns to chaos and is re-created, its economy renewed by catastrophe. Linguistically the Emission is a throwing-out, *выброс*, *викид*; its Greek equivalent is *ekbolē*, the word used in Acts 27:18 for the

jettisoning of cargo by sailors in a storm. The Zone periodically lightens itself by casting out.

Nietzsche's demon in *The Gay Science* (§341) asks whether one could will the eternal recurrence of one's life; the stalker who returns again and again to the Zone answers in practice. But the Emission's deepest significance is the domestication of apocalypse. The red sky that in Revelation marks the end of history here marks Tuesday. Catastrophe has become weather, a recurring hazard to be timed and sheltered from, after which trade resumes at the bar. Fredric Jameson's remark, often repeated by Mark Fisher, that it is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism finds its ludic literalization: in the Zone the world ends every few days, and the market reopens in the morning.



Chapter 6

The Thrown Bolt: Ballistic Hermeneutics and the Epistemology of Anomaly

6.1 The Transmission of a Gesture

The most philosophically consequential object in *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* is not an artifact, a weapon, or a god. It is an ordinary steel bolt, available in unlimited supply, which the player may throw ahead to discover whether the air conceals an anomaly. The gesture has a precise genealogy. In *Roadside Picnic*, Red tests the ground with nuts and bolts before stepping. In Tarkovsky's *Stalker*, the gesture becomes liturgical: the Stalker ties strips of cloth to steel nuts, throws them, and follows only where they fall without incident, so that the path through the Zone is a sequence of small acts of humility. In GSC's series the gesture becomes a mechanic: a bolt arcs through the air, and its trajectory, deflection, sudden acceleration, or disappearance reveals the invisible field it crosses. Three media transmit one gesture across thirty-five years, and in each it expresses the same epistemological axiom: in the Zone, knowledge is not obtained by looking but by throwing. The games' own folk speech treats the gesture as routine: a stalker's directions to one anomalous site in Call of Pripyat advise simply throwing bolts as usual. The gesture has since left the series: a mod that brings S.T.A.L.K.E.R.-style anomalies to Arma Reforger advertises that thrown objects trip them in the classic way, the bolt test.

The bolt is the minimal unit of knowledge in the series, and it has four properties that together define an epistemology. It is *material*, a thing among things, not a concept. It is *expendable*, valuable precisely because it is worthless. It is *indirect*, revealing the anomaly not by representing it but by being affected by it. And it is *risk-displacing*: it goes where the knower's body would otherwise have to go, so that its deviation stands in for the knower's death. The bolt is the stalker's proxy in the field of the unknown. This chapter calls the interpretive practice it founds **ballistic hermeneutics**.

6.2 The Lexicon of Throwing

The Introduction noted the convergence of East Slavic and German vocabularies of throwing on the Zone. The Greek root *ballein*, "to throw," extends the convergence into the conceptual foundations of Western thought, and the extension is not ornamental. A *problēma*, from *proballein*, is literally something thrown forward: a promontory, a shield held before the body, a task set before the mind. The bolt is a problem in this exact sense, a thing thrown ahead to meet what lies ahead. A *symbolon*, from *symballein*, is something thrown together: originally the two halves of a broken token whose rejoining proved a bond between their holders. A *diabolos*, from *diaballein*, is one who throws across, who sets apart, accuses, and divides. A *parabolē* is a throwing-beside, a comparison; a *hyperbolē*, a throwing-beyond, an excess; an *emblēma*, a thing thrown in, an inlay; a *metabolē*, a throwing-across into another state, a change. *Ekbolē* is a throwing-out, the jettisoning of cargo in Acts 27:18. And *katabolē*, a throwing-down, is the word the New Testament uses for the foundation of the world (Matthew 25:34).

The Zone instantiates every term of this lexicon. Its foundation, its *katabolē*, was a throwing-down: the explosion that founded it. Its Emission is an *ekbolē*. Its artifacts undergo *metabolē*, matter thrown into new states. Its legends are *hyperbolai*, tales thrown beyond belief. Its central temptation is *diabolic*, the Wish Granter that throws the wisher apart from others. Its community, as Chapter 14 will argue, is *symbolic*, a gathering of broken halves. And its fundamental epistemic act is *problematic*, the bolt thrown forward.

German completes the figure at the level of existential ontology. In *Being and Time* (1927), Heidegger described Dasein as *geworfen*, thrown into a world it did not choose, and as existing by way of *Entwurf*, projection, literally a throwing-forth of itself toward its possibilities. Dasein is *geworfener Entwurf*, thrown projection. The stalker's bolt is this structure made gesture. A being thrown into the Zone, without having chosen it and often without remembering how, throws ahead of itself a projectile whose trajectory discloses the world's hidden structure. Heidegger's disclosure (*Erschlossenheit*) is here not a matter of mood or understanding but of ballistics. Mallarmé's *Un coup de dés jamais n'abolira le hasard* (1897) supplies the appropriate caution. A throw of the dice will never abolish chance, and a throw of the bolt will never abolish the anomaly: it locates it, for a moment, along one trajectory. Ballistic knowledge is local, provisional, and revocable by the next Emission.

6.3 Sounding the Zone

In the account of Paul's shipwreck, the sailors, fearing that they are nearing land in a storm, take soundings and find twenty fathoms, then fifteen (Acts 27:28). The Greek verb is *bolisantes*, from *bolis*, a thing thrown, a missile, and in nautical usage the sounding-lead heaved overboard to measure the depth beneath the keel. The stalker's

bolt is a sounding-lead for a sea of invisible forces. Its function is the sailor's: not to see the bottom, which is impossible, but to register through the behaviour of a thrown weight how far the danger lies beneath. Maritime navigation before instruments was a ballistic hermeneutics, reading depth through the line's descent, current through the drift of a log, and the stalker's practice reinstates this pre-instrumental empiricism inside a landscape saturated with the debris of instrumental modernity. The series also stages the limits of that reinstatement. In Call of Pripyat the prototype Svarog detector, named like the Veles for a Slavic god, maps anomalies on its own display, and the community wiki notes that it leaves the bolt only two tasks: setting off certain anomalies and finding the edges of the largest gravitational fields. Instruments named for gods take over the routine work of knowledge; the thrown bolt keeps the limits.

The English word compounds the resonance. A *bolt* is the short, heavy arrow of the crossbow and, in the phrase "a bolt from the blue," the thunderbolt. The anomaly called Electro discharges lightning at whatever crosses it, and the series' protagonist is born, as Chapter 11 will show, from a truck struck by lightning. The thrown bolt is answered by the Zone's own bolts. Knowledge and danger exchange the same projectile.

6.4 The Evidential Paradigm and the *Sledopyt*

Carlo Ginzburg's essay "Clues: Roots of an Evidential Paradigm" (1979) traced a mode of knowledge that reasons from apparently negligible traces to hidden realities: the connoisseur Giovanni Morelli attributing paintings by the shape of earlobes, Freud reading the unconscious in slips, Conan Doyle's Holmes reading crimes in cigar ash. Ginzburg located its origin in the hunter, crouched in the mud, reconstructing from tracks, broken twigs, and tufts of hair the movements of an invisible animal, and he suggested that narrative itself may have arisen from this act of reading. The native Russian word for such a hunter, *следопыт*, the tracker or pathfinder, is a compound of *след*, trace, and *пытать*, to try or interrogate. The Strugatskys chose Kipling's anglicism over this native word, but the *sledopyt* is the stalker's true ancestor, and the Zone is a landscape that can be read only evidentially.

Ballistic hermeneutics, however, extends the evidential paradigm in a decisive respect. Ginzburg's hunter reads traces that the world has left; the stalker *produces* the traces he reads. The bolt is an experiment in the strict sense, an intervention designed to elicit a sign, and its logic is what Charles Sanders Peirce called abduction: from a surprising fact (the bolt veered) to the hypothesis that would render it unsurprising (a gravitational anomaly lies there). The stalker thus occupies the hinge between the hunter's reading of signs and the scientist's provocation of them, joined by the *mētis* that Chapter 1 identified as his characteristic intelligence. His knowledge is neither contemplative nor theoretical. It is a practical science of provoked traces,

conducted with the body at stake. The games' own encyclopaedia builds this into its taxonomy, describing the Springboard as revealable by throwing objects into it; and a bolt that triggers such a field leaves it briefly harmless, so that the provoked sign also buys a moment of safe passage. Knowledge here is a provocation that purchases time.

6.5 Apophasis and Learned Ignorance

The anomaly is never seen. What is seen is its effect on what is thrown: the shimmer of displaced air, the bolt's deflection, the corpse at the field's edge. The anomaly is known only by what it does to others, never in itself. This is the structure of apophatic theology. Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite taught in the *Mystical Theology* that God is approached by negation, through the stripping away of every predicate, into a darkness beyond knowledge. Gregory of Nyssa's *Life of Moses* described the ascent of Sinai as entry into a luminous darkness in which God is known as unknowable. Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) named the highest knowledge a learned ignorance, the knowledge of the precise form and limit of one's not-knowing. Vladimir Lossky's *The Mystical Theology of the Eastern Church* (1944) argued that apophaticism is the fundamental character of Orthodox theology, the refusal to enclose the divine in concepts. Mikhail Epstein traced the same current into the ruins of Soviet atheism: his 1982 essay on minimal religion described a post-atheist faith that meets the divine only in the poverty of its manifestation, where whatever is revealed is also concealed, and he later followed the line explicitly from apophatic theology to that "poor religion."

The stalker practises an apophaticism of matter. His knowledge of the anomaly is a *docta ignorantia*: he knows exactly where the bolt deviated, and he knows that he does not know why. This is the epistemological opposite of the C-Consciousness, which embodies a cataphatic hubris, the pretension to total positive knowledge of the human psyche and the planetary mind. Theodor Adorno's *Negative Dialectics* (1966) offers a secular analogue: the object is never exhausted by its concept, and thought must attend to the non-identical remainder that every concept leaves. The anomaly is the non-identical made physical. Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) defined the eerie as constituted by a failure of absence or a failure of presence, something where there should be nothing, or nothing where there should be something. An anomaly field is both: an empty patch of air that contains a lethal something, and a place where a body that should be there is not.

6.6 Kuhn at Yantar

In *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (1962), Thomas Kuhn showed that normal science proceeds within a paradigm until accumulated anomalies, observations the paradigm cannot accommodate, provoke a crisis and eventually a revolution. The

Zone is a field of anomalies in Kuhn's exact sense, and the scientists' bunker at Yantar, where Professor Sakharov and his colleagues study the Zone from inside an armoured enclosure, is the site of a permanent crisis without revolution. The scientists measure, catalogue, and theorize, but their instruments register effects without causes, and their dependence on stalkers for samples inverts the expected hierarchy of knowledge. The trained researcher commissions the uneducated trespasser, because only the trespasser's body can reach the evidence.

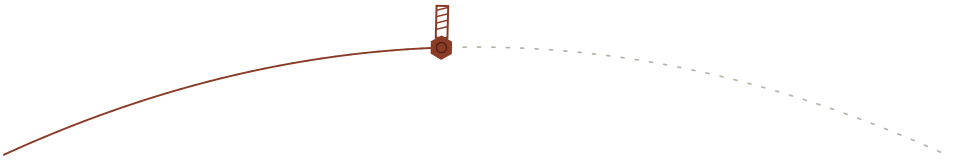
Paul Feyerabend's *Against Method* (1975) argued that no fixed methodology governs scientific progress and that folk knowledge, myth, and practical craft have repeatedly outperformed official science. The Zone vindicates Feyerabend. The stalkers' accumulated lore (which anomalies drift, which artifacts cluster near which fields, how long after an Emission a path stays safe) is more reliable than the scientists' models. The series does not thereby endorse anti-science. It stages a science that has lost its sovereignty and must learn humility from practice. The Strugatskys' homeostatic universe, which defends itself against discoveries that threaten its balance, is the ultimate Kuhnian nightmare, a nature that withholds its anomalies from resolution. In the Zone, the anomaly is not a stage on the way to a new paradigm. It is the paradigm.

6.7 Taboo Names

The stalkers' names for anomalies constitute a folk semiotics of terror. The acidic anomaly that the English localization calls Fruit Punch is in Russian *Холодец*, *kholodets*, the jellied meat aspic of the Soviet holiday table. It descends directly from the Strugatskys' *ведьмин студень*, "witches' jelly," a colloidal substance that dissolves whatever it touches. The thermal anomaly is *Жарка*, "Burner" or, more literally, a frying heat; the gravitational anomalies are "Springboard" and the "Whirligig" or "Carousel" that lifts and tears its victim; the electrical anomaly is simply "Electro"; the drifting fibres that burn on contact are "Burnt Fuzz," after the Strugatskys' "burning fluff." The Strugatskys' gravitational "mosquito mange" stands behind the whole family.

These names domesticate. They render the lethal in the vocabulary of the kitchen, the playground, and the fairground, and in doing so they follow one of the oldest strategies of East Slavic speech. The Slavic word for bear, *медведь*, means "honey-eater"; it is generally explained as a taboo replacement for the inherited Indo-European name, avoided lest speaking it summon the beast. The stalkers' names for anomalies are taboo-euphemisms of the same kind: to call a field of dissolving acid "aspic" is to refuse it the dignity of its own terror and to bring it within the circle of the familiar. *Call of Pripyat*, whose most advanced artifact detectors carry the names of Slavic deities, also calls one of them "Bear," as though the old taboo animal had become an instrument of the very search it once forbade. In Lotman's terms, the folk

names are acts of translation at the boundary of the semiosphere, where the untranslatable is given provisional meaning by comparison with the known. They are, in the vocabulary of this chapter, parables: things thrown beside the unknown so that it may be approached without being named.



Chapter 7

Hylophany: Artifact, Fetish, Pharmakon, and the Bestiary of Degenerate Modernity

7.1 Hylophany Defined

The artifact is the Zone's characteristic object, and it requires a new term. Mircea Eliade called the manifestation of the sacred in a stone, a tree, or a place a *hierophany*, and the manifestation of power a *kratophany*. The artifact is neither. It manifests no transcendent sacred and no divine power; it manifests matter itself behaving as matter should not. This thesis therefore calls it a **hylophany**, from *hylē*, matter, and *phainein*, to show: an appearance of matter as other than every concept imposed upon it. A crystalline growth that accelerates the healing of wounds, a translucent mass that absorbs radiation, a gravitational knot that lightens a burden: these are not tools, because no one designed them, and not natural kinds, because no science classifies them. They are matter showing itself.

Heidegger's lecture "The Thing" (1950) distinguished the object, which stands over against a representing subject, from the thing, which gathers a world around itself, as the jug gathers earth, sky, mortals, and divinities in the pouring of wine. The artifact is a Heideggerian thing gone strange: it gathers a world, but the world it gathers is the Zone's, with its anomalies, its traders, its deaths, and its legends. Graham Harman's object-oriented ontology, in which every object withdraws from all its relations, finds in the artifact its most literal illustration: the artifact yields effects but never its essence, and the scientists at Yantar who place it under every instrument receive only its surface. Jane Bennett's *Vibrant Matter* recognized agency in things, but the artifact's agency is ambivalent before it is vibrant. It heals and irradiates, protects and poisons, and the question of what it is cannot be separated from the question of what it costs.

7.2 The Commodity Fetish Literalized

In the first chapter of *Capital* (1867), Marx observed that a commodity appears at first sight a trivial thing but proves on analysis to be very strange, full of metaphysical subtleties and theological whims. A table, once it emerges as a commodity, seems to stand on its head and to evolve grotesque ideas out of its wooden brain. The fetishism of commodities is the process by which social relations between producers appear as relations between things, and things appear to possess powers that are in truth the congealed labour of human beings. The artifact is the commodity fetish literalized. It really does possess powers; it really is a thing with metaphysical subtleties; and it really conceals the social relation that produced it, namely the stalker's mortal risk, which disappears from view at the moment of sale.

The Zone's political economy is an allegory of the post-Soviet transition. Sidorovich, sealed in his bunker at the Cordon, buys artifacts from desperate rookies at a fraction of their value and sells them to buyers outside; the Barman, under Duty's protection, mediates a more prosperous trade; scientists purchase samples with equipment. The chain of intermediaries is the chain of the 1990s, when the dissolution of the planned economy unleashed what Ukrainians and Russians called wild capitalism. Popular speech coined *прихватизация*, a pun fusing "privatization" with "grabbing," for the transfer of state assets to the well connected. Bandits in tracksuits and leather jackets, extorting protection money (*крыша*, literally "roof"), populate the Garbage and the Dark Valley exactly as racketeers populated the markets of Kyiv and Kharkiv. Marx's account of primitive accumulation, in Part VIII of *Capital*, described capital's origin in expropriation by force; the Zone restages it in a territory where the state has withdrawn and the market has arrived armed.

Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) introduced *salvage accumulation* for the process by which capitalism draws value from things produced outside capitalist relations, as matsutake mushrooms gathered by foragers in ruined forests enter global commodity chains through buyers who translate wild abundance into inventory. The artifact is the purest instance of salvage accumulation in modern fiction. It is produced by no labour and no capital, by the anomalies alone; it is gathered by foragers in the ruins of a planned economy; and it is translated into value by the trader, who stands at the point where the Zone's non-capitalist ecology meets the market.

7.3 Pharmakon and Amulet

Shadow of Chernobyl contains a quirk that stages this section's argument before it is made. Stack four Battery artifacts and the Marked One's protection against electricity exceeds a hundred per cent; the Electro anomaly, which kills, begins instead to heal him. Poison turns remedy at the edge of the algorithm's arithmetic, as though

the code itself knew that the Zone's gifts and its wounds are one substance measured from opposite sides.

Most artifacts confer a benefit at a cost, typically radiation, so that the player must balance one artifact against another on a belt of limited slots. Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the Greek *pharmakon*, in the *Phaedrus*'s judgment on writing, means both remedy and poison, and that its meaning cannot be stabilized on either side. The artifact is a pharmakon without remainder: every artifact that heals also harms, and the stalker's belt is a pharmacy in which the body's equilibrium is maintained by a calculus of counter-poisons. The series extends this pharmacology into folk medicine. In *Shadow of Chernobyl*, vodka reduces radiation, a mechanic that preserves the folk belief, widespread among liquidators, that alcohol protected against exposure. The bottle carries the brand name Cossacks, after GSC's own strategy series of 2001, so the studio's first success, named for the Cossack past, is bottled as the stalker's remedy; and vodka has remained a radiation remedy in every instalment since, the sequel included. The stalker's body is a pharmacological ledger, balanced by remedies that are also toxins and by superstitions that the game honours as rules. The kindred word *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city in times of crisis, completes the figure: the stalker himself, expelled to the Zone and returning with its poisoned gifts, is the community's pharmakos.

The artifact is also an amulet. The Greek *phylaktērion* designated both a guardpost and a protective charm, and the artifacts on the stalker's belt are apotropaic in function, warding off burns, shocks, chemical damage, and psychic assault. The belt is a string of amulets, and the stalker who wears it practises a magic indistinguishable from medicine. Walter Benjamin's "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility" (1935–1936) defined aura as the unique apparition of a distance, however near the object may be, and argued that technical reproduction destroys it. The artifact is an auratic object in the age of digital reproducibility. Within the code it is infinitely copyable; within the diegesis it is scarce, singular, and charged with the distance of the place it came from. The game simulates aura by simulating scarcity, and the player's reverence before a rare artifact is a reverence the medium has manufactured and the Zone has made credible.

7.4 The Onomastics of Artifacts and Instruments

The artifacts' names constitute a folkloric archive. The Stone Flower recalls Pavel Bazhov's Ural tale in *The Malachite Box* (1939), in which the craftsman Danila, obsessed with carving a perfect flower in stone, is drawn into the mountain by the Mistress of the Copper Mountain: the pursuit of perfect beauty in matter leads underground, as the pursuit of artifacts leads the stalker toward the centre. The Goldfish recalls Pushkin's *Tale of the Fisherman and the Fish* (1833), in which a magic fish grants the escalating demands of an old fisherman's wife until she wishes to rule the

sea itself and is returned to her broken washtub. Every artifact is a small wish, and the Goldfish names the danger of wishing. Kolobok recalls the folk tale of the runaway bun who escapes grandfather, grandmother, hare, wolf, and bear, and is eaten by the cunning fox: the artifact evades everyone until *mētis* catches it. Mama's Beads, Soul, Night Star, Moonlight, Jellyfish, the Compass, and the Heart of the Oasis complete a nomenclature drawn from domestic life, folk religion, and the night sky, in which the uncanny is named by the familiar.

The instruments are named more pointedly. *Call of Pripyat*'s artifact detectors are called Echo, Bear, Veles, and Svarog. Veles was the East Slavic god of cattle, wealth, magic, and the underworld; the Old East Slavic word for cattle could also mean money. Svarog was the celestial smith. Vyacheslav Ivanov and Vladimir Toporov reconstructed a Proto-Slavic "basic myth" in which the thunderer Perun pursues Veles, the serpentine adversary who steals cattle and hides beneath trees, stones, and waters, until Perun's bolt strikes and rain returns to the land. The reconstruction remains debated, not least over why this myth should count as basic, but its pairing of thunderer and serpent has become a standard frame for Slavic myth. The instruments that locate wealth hidden in the Zone's underworld are thus named for the god of wealth and the underworld and for the god of the forge, and they operate in a territory whose Emissions resemble Perun's storms. The naming belongs to a wider post-Soviet return of Slavic paganism, and it renders the stalker's technology as a small pantheon: a techno-paganism in which scientific instruments carry the names of gods that Volodymyr threw into the Dnieper.

7.5 Teratology: Slavic Demonology Recoded

Georges Canguilhem's "Monstrosity and the Monstrous" (1962) described the monster as a living being of negative value, a counter-example whose existence reveals the fragility of the norm it violates. Foucault's lectures on *Abnormal* (1974–1975) traced the human monster as a juridico-biological figure transgressing at once the laws of nature and the laws of society. The Zone's bestiary is a teratology of degenerate modernity, and, as Chapter 4 proposed, its creatures are the archetypal fears of East Slavic culture released by a failed attempt to purge them.

The bloodsucker, which stalks invisibly and feeds through a tentacled mouth, is the *upyr* of Slavic folklore restored to flesh. The poltergeist, unseen and hurling objects, is the domestic spirit, the *domovoi*, turned malign in houses its families abandoned. The controller, a hairless humanoid that seizes minds with its gaze, is the evil eye and the village sorcerer fused with the Soviet hypnotist. The burer, a hooded dwarf that tears weapons from the player's hands by telekinesis, belongs to the same family of domestic and subterranean spirits, and with the poltergeist it shares a ballistic signature: these creatures throw. The Zone throws back. For the burer, the series' own encyclopaedia makes the political referent explicit: it is the product of

secret-service genetic experiments on criminals, in a programme to develop human telekinesis. The camp and the psychotronic laboratory meet in a single body. The pseudogiant, whose stamp shakes the earth, is Soviet gigantism made flesh; the chimera, a two-headed predator, is hybridity itself. Two further figures are specifically political. The snorks, former soldiers who crawl and leap in tattered gas masks, whose origin stalker lore variously traces to contamination, psychic exposure, or the laboratories' experiments, are the state's own body degenerated, the uniformed instrument of order reduced to animal motion. The figure has a precise historical referent. In the autumn of 1986, after remote-controlled machines failed in the radiation field, thousands of conscripts and reservists were sent onto the roof of the ruined reactor, in shifts measured in seconds, to clear radioactive graphite by hand: the state used its soldiers as the machines it lacked. The zombies, former stalkers who shuffle and fire and mutter fragments of speech, embody what Alexei Yurchak's *Everything Was Forever, Until It Was No More* (2006) called hypernormalization: the late-Soviet condition in which authoritative forms were reproduced while their content drained away. The zombie repeats the form of a stalker after the stalker is gone.

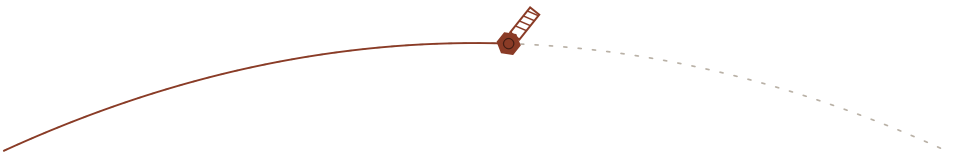
The dogs require separate notice. Blind dogs, pseudodogs, and psy-dogs that project phantom doubles of themselves roam in packs across the series. Svetlana Alexievich's oral history of Chornobyl records the squads of hunters and soldiers that the authorities dispatched to shoot the animals left behind in evacuated villages, for fear that pets carrying radiation in their fur would wander out of the Zone; she remembered the abandoned cats and dogs gathering around the evacuation buses. The Zone's dogs are revenant animals: the abandoned pets of 1986, returned as predators to the land from which their owners fled. The series also allows the reverse: in one ending the Doctor appears in a remote swamp with a tamed pseudodog for company, kinship restored across the line the Zone drew between human and mutant. The real Zone has made the same turn: the descendants of the dogs that survived are now fed, vaccinated, and sterilized by volunteers of the Clean Futures Fund's Dogs of Chernobyl programme. Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (published 2006) asked what it means to be seen by an animal; the Zone's dogs ask what it means to be hunted by the animals one abandoned. Mikhail Bakhtin's grotesque body, in *Rabelais and His World*, was open, protruding, unfinished, and regenerative, a body of birth as much as death. The Zone's grotesque is the same body stripped of regeneration: carnival without renewal, a festival of deformity that produces no new life, only further degeneration.

7.6 The Effaced Face

Emmanuel Levinas grounded ethics in the face of the other, whose nakedness and vulnerability utter the primordial command not to kill (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961). The first-person shooter is the genre that must suspend this command to function,

and the Zone supplies the means of suspension: it effaces faces. The Monolith's fighters wear masks; the snorks wear gas masks; the stalkers themselves wear respirators and sealed suits. Zombies' faces are decayed; mutants have muzzles, tentacles, or no recognizable faces at all. The gas mask is the emblem of the Zone's ethics, at once a protection against invisible poison and an effacement that renders the other killable.

Against this general effacement stands the campfire. There, stalkers sit unmasked in the firelight, tell jokes, play guitar, and pass the night; there, the player who approaches with weapon holstered is greeted rather than fired upon. The campfire is the one place in the Zone where faces appear. Chapter 14 will argue that this is not an incidental feature of the series' social simulation but the germ of its ethical alternative, the place where the Levinasian face returns to a world built to efface it.



Chapter 8

The Political Theology of the Factions

8.1 The Zone as State of Nature

The Zone is a laboratory of political philosophy in which every doctrine has been reduced to an armed group. Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) imagined a condition without a common power, a war of every man against every man, in which there is "no place for industry" and the life of man is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" (ch. 13). The Zone is that condition with one modification: it contains not isolated individuals but rival associations, each a miniature Leviathan claiming to have escaped the state of nature by subordinating its members to a cause. *Clear Sky*'s faction-war system makes this explicit as gameplay, allowing territories to change hands as groups advance and retreat across the map.

Carl Schmitt's *The Concept of the Political* (1932) defined the political by the distinction between friend and enemy, a distinction prior to every moral, aesthetic, or economic criterion. The factional Zone is Schmittian in its purest form. The player's relation to every armed figure is determined first by faction standing, displayed in the colour of a name, and only then by any assessment of conduct. Politics in the Zone is the art of knowing, at a distance and through a scope, who may be shot.

8.2 Duty, or Debt

Duty is a disciplined paramilitary order dedicated to containing the Zone, exterminating its mutants, and preventing its expansion into the world. Under General Voronin it holds the Rostok factory and guarantees the security of the Bar, imposing order on the Zone's most important commercial hub. Its own legend begins with a bomb: the community wiki records that the order was founded by a Captain Tachenko, whose squad of army specialists had been sent to destroy the Zone's centre with nuclear explosives. Duty begins where Tarkovsky's Professor ends, carrying a bomb toward the centre; and at the gate of its base a megaphone broadcasts recruitment slogans about its march to save the planet, in the idiom of the Soviet loudspeaker. Its name is a

philological event. Russian *долг* means both "duty" and "debt." In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887), Nietzsche argued that the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) descended from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*), and that conscience was born in the relation between creditor and debtor. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) extended the argument across economic history. Duty embodies the Nietzschean genealogy in a single word. Its members understand themselves as paying a debt owed by humanity to itself for the catastrophe of 1986, a debt that can never be discharged because the Zone keeps generating new obligations.

Duty's ethic is Kantian in form. The *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785) located moral worth in action done from duty rather than inclination, and Duty's members renounce the profits of the artifact trade to serve a universal imperative of containment. Its political theology is that of the *katechon*, the restraining power of 2 Thessalonians 2:7 ("only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way"), which Schmitt in *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) interpreted as the force that holds back the end. Duty is the Zone's katechon. It restrains the expansion of the anomalous into the human world, and it accepts a monastic discipline as the price of restraint. Its tragedy is that the Zone cannot be restrained, only fought; its katechontic labour has no end because the eschaton it holds back is already present.

8.3 Freedom, or Negative Liberty

Freedom, Duty's sworn enemy, holds the Army Warehouses under its leader Lukash and professes that the Zone belongs to humanity: its wonders should be open to all, its secrets shared, and no state or military order should monopolize it. Its members are casual, ironic, and openly given to intoxication, its members shown in regular recreational use of alcohol and cannabis. Isaiah Berlin's "Two Concepts of Liberty" (1958) distinguished negative liberty, freedom from interference, from positive liberty, freedom to realize a rational self, and warned that positive liberty, claimed on behalf of a higher self, licenses coercion. Freedom is a faction of negative liberty, suspicious of every claim to know what others should become. Its genealogy runs through Max Stirner's *The Ego and Its Own* (1844), which dissolved every "spook" of duty, state, and humanity into the self-assertion of the unique individual, and through Mikhail Bakunin's anarchism, with its hostility to every authority not freely accepted.

Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872) opposed the Apollonian principle of form, measure, and individuation to the Dionysian principle of intoxication and dissolution. Duty is Apollonian; Freedom is Dionysian. But Freedom's deepest claim is not hedonistic. It is the claim that the Zone is a commons, a resource that should not be enclosed. In this respect Freedom carries the series' most serious political proposition, one that Chapter 14 will find realized not in the diegesis but in the community of players who have kept the Zone open for nearly two decades.

8.4 Mimetic Doubles

Duty and Freedom are opposites in doctrine and identical in practice. Both are armed militias with fortified bases, chains of command, and lethal hostility toward the other. René Girard's *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (1961) and *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) argued that desire is mimetic, borrowed from a model who becomes a rival, and that rivalry escalates until the antagonists become "monstrous doubles," indistinguishable in the violence they inflict on each other. The war between Duty and Freedom is a mimetic war. Each defines itself by negating the other, and each reproduces the other's structure. The Zone has no need of a scapegoat because it has two, each serving as the other's. The game's ending logic registers the same structure: the player who kills the leaders of both Duty and Freedom is computed, at the Granter, to wish to rule the world, and is absorbed into the Monolith (Chapter 9).

The series nevertheless allows the war to be suspended. In *Call of Pripyat*, members of both factions coexist at Yanov station under the pressure of a shared environment, and their truce, fragile and continually threatened, demonstrates that the war is structural rather than essential. Chapter 12 reads this truce through Kant. Here it suffices to note that the factions' ideological difference is less important than their formal identity: both are forms of what this thesis calls the Creed, the response to the unknown that divides the world into friends and enemies and seeks to master the Zone by mastering one's rivals.

8.5 Monolith: The Shadow of God in the Cave

The Monolith faction consists of fanatics who guard the approaches to the Zone's centre and venerate the crystalline Monolith in the Sarcophagus as a god. Their fighters advance in masked silence, apparently indifferent to death, and the series reveals that their faith is engineered: they are held in psychic thrall by emitters operated by the C-Consciousness. Nietzsche's *The Gay Science* contains an aphorism (§108) on the persistence of dead gods. After the Buddha died, his shadow was shown in a cave for centuries; God is dead, Nietzsche writes, but human beings being what they are, there may be caves for thousands of years in which his shadow will still be shown, and we must vanquish his shadow too. The Monolith is the shadow of God shown in a cave. The cave is the Sarcophagus, the flesh-eating stone at the heart of the Zone, and the shadow is an idol manufactured by human beings who had themselves aspired to divinity.

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor identified three forces by which human beings may be held captive: miracle, mystery, and authority. The Monolith faction is organized by all three. Its miracle is the wish-granting stone; its mystery is the hidden intelligence behind the stone; its authority is the psychic command that leaves its members no room for doubt. Chapter 4 noted the Monolith's resemblance to the glass coffin of Lenin's Mausoleum, Cosmism's monument to scientific immortality. Arthur C.

Clarke and Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) supplies a further reference: its black monolith uplifts the hominids who touch it, catalysing tools, intelligence, and finally transcendence. GSC's Monolith inverts the figure. It downlifts, stripping its worshippers of will and reducing them to instruments. Where Clarke's monolith is an alien gift of evolution, GSC's is a human idol of involution. Mikhail Epstein described the faith that emerged after Soviet atheism as a "minimal religion," a belief without dogma or institution; the Monolith faction is its opposite, a maximal religion that leaves its adherents nothing but faith.

8.6 The Economies of Force

Three further groups embody force without ideology. The bandits, with their tracksuits, criminal cant, and protection rackets, are the 1990s transposed into the Zone, the armed face of primitive accumulation analysed in Chapter 7. Their leader in the Dark Valley, Borov, controls access to the X18 laboratory as racketeers controlled access to the privatized assets of the planned economy. The mercenaries, well equipped and loyal only to contracts, are the market in its military form, the private violence that fills the space vacated by the state. The military at the Cordon is the state itself, reduced to a necropolitical function: it does not govern the Zone but merely kills those who cross its line.

Together these groups constitute the Zone's economies of force: the criminal, the commercial, and the sovereign. None professes a doctrine about the Zone's meaning. Each treats the Zone as a space to be controlled for profit or for security. Their presence ensures that the ideological factions' debates take place amid a constant pressure of violence that is indifferent to all ideas.

8.7 The Ascetic Priests of Method

The scientists, sheltered in their bunker at Yantar or, in *Clear Sky*, organized in Lebedev's faction of researchers, embody the Zone's most sympathetic and most fragile authority. In the third essay of the *Genealogy*, Nietzsche argued that modern science is not the opponent of the ascetic ideal but its latest and noblest form: the will to truth at any cost is itself an ascetic renunciation, a denial of life in the service of an absolute. The Zone's scientists are ascetic priests of method. They renounce safety, comfort, and profit for knowledge, and their renunciation is genuine. Yet they cannot leave their shelters, and they depend for every sample on stalkers whose knowledge they cannot formalize. Their authority is moral rather than practical. Clear Sky's fate, analysed in Chapter 12, is the tragedy of a scientific vanguard that believed understanding would yield control.

8.8 Loners: Life *Vnye*

The largest population of the Zone belongs to no ideology. The Loners, *одиночки*, are unaffiliated stalkers who share campfires, trade information, help one another when they can, and kill one another rarely. They are a faction of non-faction, a loose association bound by custom rather than doctrine. Alexei Yurchak's study of the last Soviet generation identified a characteristic mode of existence he called *vnye*, "outside": living within the system while being neither for nor against it, participating in its forms while inhabiting deterritorialized milieus of friendship, art, and talk where its authoritative discourse lost its hold. The Loners live *vnye*. They are inside the Zone but outside every faction's claim upon it, and their characteristic spaces, the campfire, the abandoned village, the shared shelter during an Emission, are the deterritorialized milieus of the post-Soviet ruin.

Victor Turner's *communitas* and Jean-Luc Nancy's inoperative community will supply, in Chapter 14, the theoretical terms for what the Loners embody. Here it suffices to observe that the series' ideological factions are defined by what they want to do with the Zone, whereas the Loners are defined by how they live in it. The Wish, the Plan, the Creed, and the Idol each propose a relation of mastery: to exploit, to engineer, to defend, to worship. The Loners propose no relation of mastery at all, only a relation of passage. Their farewell, "good hunting, stalker," is the series' minimal political theology: a blessing that wishes the other neither victory nor salvation, only safe return.



Chapter 9

The Wish Granter and the Algorithmic Room

9.1 Sphere, Room, Granter

The wish-granting centre is the Zone's oldest and most stable mythologeme, and each work in the lineage reconfigures it. In *Roadside Picnic* it is the Golden Sphere, a copper-coloured object at the bottom of a quarry, reached by sacrifice and answered by a universal wish whose effect the novel withholds. In Tarkovsky's *Stalker* it is the Room, a dim interior beyond a threshold that no one crosses, governed by the Porcupine principle that it grants the innermost rather than the professed desire. In *Shadow of Chernobyl* it is the Wish Granter, a legend that circulates among stalkers at campfires and that the protagonist pursues to the heart of the Sarcophagus, where it proves to be the Monolith itself.

The progression is from object to place to machine. The Sphere is a thing, the Room a space, the Granter an apparatus. Each step deepens the centre's opacity and its danger. The Sphere's response is unknown, the Room's response is feared, and the Granter's response is shown, in five variants, each lethal or worse. GSC's innovation is not the idea of a malign wish-granter, which is ancient, but the mechanism by which the wish is determined, analysed below as the algorithmic Room.

9.2 The False Endings and Their Mythic Ancestry

The player who reaches the Granter without having discovered the hidden path receives one of five endings. The wish for wealth is granted as a hallucination: the bolts and screws of the roof above him work loose and fall, he takes them for gold coins, and as he reaches to catch them the roof collapses on him. The wish for immortality turns him into a metal statue, neither living nor dead. The wish that the Zone should disappear bathes him in white light and shows him a field of grass and trees; when he opens his eyes he is blind, and the Zone has vanished only for him. The wish to rule

the world lifts him convulsing into the air until the Monolith absorbs him. The wish that humanity, being corrupt, should be controlled leaves him alone in darkness while images of nuclear detonation, desolation, and disease pour through his mind; in the original Russian he asks that humanity be destroyed, and the English localization softened the line. Every grant is literal and every grant destroys. The Wish Granter is a monkey's paw.

The mythic ancestry of these endings is precise.

Wish	Computed from	What the Granter gives	Mythic ancestry	Temptation in the desert (Matthew 4)
Wealth	50,000 roubles or more carried; overrides every other outcome	Falling bolts seen as gold, then the collapsing roof	Midas (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* XI); Pushkin's Goldfish; Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw"	Command these stones to become bread, inverted: bolts taken for gold bring down the stone
Rule the world	Both faction leaders, Voronin of Duty and Lukash of Freedom, killed	Absorption into the Monolith	Faust's bargain; the tyrant's hubris	All the kingdoms of the world, if thou wilt fall down and worship me
Humanity controlled (in Russian, destroyed)	"Terrible" reputation	Darkness and visions of the world's end	The Grand Inquisitor's contempt; the Flood	The Inquisitor's verdict on the three temptations: humanity cannot bear freedom
The Zone's disappearance	"Excellent" reputation	A vision of a clean world, then blindness	Oedipus; Tiresias	The refusal of the given world, granted as the loss of sight
Immortality	None of the above; the default	A metal statue, neither living nor dead	Tithonus (*Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite*); the Sibyl (Ovid XIV; Petronius); Niobe (Ovid VI)	Cast thyself down, for the angels shall bear thee up

Midas wished that everything he touched might turn to gold and starved among his treasures; the Granter reverses the metamorphosis, showing the wisher gold where there are only falling bolts and then burying him beneath the roof they held together. Tithonus was granted immortality without youth and withered into a cicada; the Cumaean Sibyl, granted as many years as grains of sand she held, shrank to a voice in a jar, and when the boys of Cumae asked her what she wanted, she answered, in the Greek that Petronius records and T. S. Eliot set as the epigraph to *The Waste Land*: *apothanein thelō*, "I want to die." The wish for immortality yields an eternity that is worse than death. Niobe, punished for her pride, became a weeping stone. Oedipus, who sought the truth with relentless determination, blinded himself when he found it; Tiresias, who saw the truth, was blind already. The wish that the Zone should not exist is a wish not to see what is, and it is granted as the loss of sight itself, a perfect enactment of what psychoanalysis calls disavowal.

9.3 The Three Temptations

The fourth column of the table indicates a structural correspondence that this thesis regards as the key to the Granter. In Matthew 4:1–11, Jesus is led into the wilderness "to be tempted of the devil." The Greek names the tempter in two ways within a few verses: *diabolos* (4:1), the one who throws apart, and *ho peirazōn* (4:3), the tester. The three temptations are to command stones to become bread, to cast oneself from the pinnacle of the Temple in confidence that angels will intervene, and to receive all the kingdoms of the world in exchange for worship. Christ refuses all three.

The Wish Granter is the desert tempter, and its false endings are the temptations accepted. Wealth is the temptation of bread, the satisfaction of material need, and the Granter's bitter joke is to show the wisher gold where there are only falling bolts, the stalker's own instrument of knowledge, before the roof itself comes down. The bolt that the stalker throws forward to test the ground falls on the wisher from above as hallucinated coin: the problem has become the curse. Immortality is the temptation of the pinnacle, the demand that one's body be exempted from death by miracle. Dominion is the temptation of the kingdoms. The Granter computes this wish only for the player who has killed the leaders of both Duty and Freedom, and its grant is absorption into the Monolith: the one who destroyed the heads of both creeds becomes matter for the idol, and the price the devil named, worship, is paid in full. The Granter is diabolic in both senses the Gospel supplies: it throws the wisher apart from every other human being, isolating him in his granted desire, and it tests him, revealing what he is.

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor built his indictment of Christ on these three temptations. Christ, he charged, overestimated humanity by refusing bread, miracle, and power; men want to be fed, to be amazed, and to be ruled, and the Church has corrected Christ's work by giving them all three under the forms of miracle, mystery, and authority. The Zone sets the Inquisitor's anthropology a test. If humanity truly wants bread, miracle, and power, then the Granter's victims have received what they wanted and been destroyed by it. The Zone thus confirms the Inquisitor's description of human desire while refuting his conclusion that granting it is mercy. The fifth false ending states the Inquisitor's premise outright. The player whose reputation has sunk to its lowest wishes, in the English release, that corrupt humanity be controlled, and in the Russian original that it be destroyed; the Granter answers with a vision of the world's end and leaves him alone in darkness. In its English form the wish restates the C-Consciousness's own project; in its Russian form it names where that project led. Chapter 10 will show that the Inquisitor himself waits behind the Granter, in the person of the C-Consciousness.

9.4 The Algorithmic Room

The decisive feature of the false endings is not their content but their mechanism. The player does not choose the wish. No menu appears at the Granter, and no dialogue asks what the protagonist desires. The ending is computed from accumulated conduct. Carrying 50,000 roubles or more yields the wish for wealth and overrides every other outcome; having killed the leaders of both Duty and Freedom yields the wish to rule the world; a reputation at either extreme yields, if it is terrible, the wish that humanity be controlled, or in Russian destroyed, and, if it is excellent, the wish that the Zone disappear; failing all of these, the protagonist asks for immortality. The parameters read like a census of the responses to the unknown that Chapter 14 will call diabolic. Hoarded money is the Wish. The killing of both creeds' leaders is the Creed carried to its conclusion. A terrible reputation yields the Plan's contempt for humanity. An excellent reputation yields the reformer's wish to abolish the problem rather than understand it. Bare survival, the default, asks only to go on surviving. The wish is the integral of the life. The design history sharpens the point. According to the community-maintained S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Wiki, earlier requirements would have granted immortality to a player who saved too often or avoided danger, and world rule to one who bought too many weapons. The game would have read the quicksave, the player's literal immortality, as a desire for immortality. The release keeps the principle if not the instrument: desire is inferred from play. Slavoj Žižek's contrast between Tarkovsky's two films sharpens what kind of machine this is. He sets Solaris, an ocean that materializes desire before anyone asks, against the Zone of Stalker, where the deepest wish is granted only to one who can formulate it. The algorithmic Room is a hybrid: it stages the moment of asking, as Tarkovsky's Room does, but computes the answer from conduct, as Solaris does. It is a Solaris disguised as a Room.

This thesis calls the mechanism the **algorithmic Room**, because it is the procedural realization of Tarkovsky's Porcupine principle. Porcupine went to the Room professing one wish and received another, the one his life had made. *Shadow of Chernobyl* removes even the profession: it does not ask the player what he wants, because what he says he wants is irrelevant to what he will receive. Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric names the capacity of rule systems to make arguments; the algorithmic Room's argument is that desire is not declared but enacted, legible in conduct and invisible to introspection. Alexander Galloway's thesis that a game is an allegory of control, whose true content is the algorithm the player learns to inhabit, finds here a startling application. The hidden variables are the game's unconscious, accumulating unseen while the player believes himself to be making local choices for local reasons.

Spinoza supplied the philosophical form of this argument three centuries earlier. In a letter of 1674 to G. H. Schuller (Letter 58), he imagined a stone set in motion by an external cause and endowed with consciousness: such a stone, aware only of its

endeavour to continue moving, would believe itself free and think that it moved by its own will. This, Spinoza wrote, is the human freedom that all boast of possessing, which consists solely in being conscious of one's desires while ignorant of their causes. The wisher at the Granter is Spinoza's stone. He believes he chooses; the algorithm knows the causes. And the wealth ending's concrete debris literalizes the image: the man who thought himself free is crushed by stones.

The mechanism has a lineage within Kyivan game design. *Metro 2033* (2010), developed by 4A Games, a studio founded by former GSC developers, conceals a moral accounting through which small acts of compassion and attention accrue unseen; only players who have accumulated enough are offered the ending in which Artyom recognizes the telepathic Dark Ones as seeking contact and spares them. One may speak of a Kyivan school of diagnostic narrative design, in which endings are not chosen but earned by the cumulative character of play. Finally, the algorithmic Room diagnoses even the player who tries to outwit it. The completionist who deliberately manipulates parameters to see every ending reveals a desire of his own, which Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) would recognize: the wish to possess all wishes, the archivist's fever that the Zone, too, is equipped to grant.

9.5 The Grail Question

The algorithmic Room has an exit, and its structure is medieval. In Chrétien de Troyes's *Perceval, or the Story of the Grail* (c. 1180s), the young knight witnesses the Grail procession in the castle of the wounded Fisher King and, out of misplaced courtesy, fails to ask whom the Grail serves. Because he does not ask, the king remains wounded and the land waste. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210), the redeeming question is compassionate: *œheim, waz wirret dir?*, "uncle, what ails thee?" Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) read the Grail legend as a fertility rite of the wounded land, and Eliot built *The Waste Land* upon her reading.

Shadow of Chernobyl's true endings are reserved for the player who asks. The path runs through Strelok's former companions. After the psychic emitter in laboratory X16 is shut down, the protagonist can seek out the Guide, whose errands lead him to the Doctor, the last surviving member of Strelok's group, hiding in Strelok's old refuge. The Doctor tells him that the Wish Granter is an illusion manufactured by a secret laboratory beside the Sarcophagus, and gives him the location of a stash in Pripyat that holds the group's notes and a decoder, built by their dead comrade Fang, for a locked door inside the Sarcophagus. With it the player bypasses the Granter and reaches the intelligence behind it. The condition of access is not a wish but a question: what is the Zone, who made it, and what was done to me? Only here does the game offer a genuine, declared choice. Freedom, in the Zone, is withheld from the wisher and granted to the questioner, as the healing of the waste land is withheld from the knight who wishes for nothing but asks nothing, and granted to the one who

asks what ails it. The Granter tests desire; the hidden door tests inquiry; and the game's moral architecture ranks inquiry above desire as the only path to a decision that is one's own.

9.6 Whose Desire?

The wishes the Granter grants are revealing in their conventionality: wealth, immortality, power, the abolition of the troubling. They are not the eccentric desires of particular individuals but the generic desires of a civilization. Lacan's formula that desire is the desire of the Other, and Girard's thesis that desire is borrowed from models, converge on the Zone's verdict: private desire is not private. The wisher at the Granter receives society's desire disguised as his own, and is destroyed by the disguise.

The Strugatskys had already staged this predicament in Red's aphasia before the Sphere, where he found that his soul possessed no words but those his world had given it. GSC mechanizes the predicament and darkens it. Red borrowed a boy's generous words; the Granter's wisher borrows nothing, because his wish was computed from a life lived in the Zone's economy of hoarding, fighting, and allegiance. The algorithmic Room is the Zone's judgment on the economy that produced it. Those who lived by its terms receive its terms as their fate. Only those who stepped outside its terms to ask what it was are permitted to decide what to do with it.



Chapter 10

The C-Consciousness, or the Noospheric Inquisitor

10.1 The Revelation at the Centre

Beyond the hidden door of the Sarcophagus, the protagonist meets the intelligence that the Wish Granter concealed. Past a hologram of the Wish Granter, ringed by orbs that he must destroy, the image becomes that of a man: the C-Consciousness, presenting many minds through a single human face. It gives an account of itself, here paraphrased. It was once a group of scientists who, after long research into the noosphere, fused their minds into a single collective consciousness. Their aim was to reach into the shared psyche of humanity and remove from it the impulses that produce cruelty, envy, and war. The intervention ruptured the noosphere and brought the Zone into being. Since then the collective has defended the centre against intrusion, through the Brain Scorcher, through the Monolith and its programmed worshippers, and through the capture and reprogramming of those who come too close. Strelok was one of these. Captured on his earlier approach, he was wiped and sent back into the Zone with a single instruction, to kill Strelok: an assassin dispatched against himself. It explains, too, the purpose of the death trucks and the meaning of the acronym tattooed on his arm. The collective now offers him a choice. He may join it, or he may refuse.

The scene is the series' philosophical apex, and it reconfigures everything that preceded it. The Wish Granter was a trap, the Monolith a puppet, the Brain Scorcher a wall, and all of them instruments of a single will that had sought to perfect humanity and produced a hell. The Zone's demiurge is not a god or an alien but a committee of perfectionists. Its tone is not malevolence but tragic paternalism. It believes, still, that it acted for humanity's good.

10.2 The Grand Inquisitor of Pripyat

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, in Ivan Karamazov's poem (1880), confronts the returned Christ in sixteenth-century Seville and explains why the Church has corrected his work. Human beings, he argues, cannot bear freedom; they want bread, miracle, and authority, and the few who are strong enough to bear the knowledge of good and evil have taken upon themselves the burden of governing the many, who will live and die as happy children, deceived for their own good. The C-Consciousness is the Grand Inquisitor of the noosphere. It is the few who bear knowledge on behalf of the many; it has judged humanity incapable of freedom from its own worst impulses; and it has taken upon itself the task of correcting human nature at its source.

Plato had supplied the Inquisitor's charter. The *Republic* (414b–415c) proposes that the guardians of the ideal city propagate a "noble lie," a myth that citizens are born with gold, silver, or bronze in their souls, so that each may accept his station. The Wish Granter and the Monolith are the C-Consciousness's noble lies: myths administered by guardians to keep intruders from the truth, and the Monolith's fighters are citizens who have accepted their station absolutely. The C-Consciousness is a council of philosopher-kings who have taken the step that Plato's guardians did not, from governing souls by myth to rewriting them by technique. The Wish Granter, the Monolith, and the C-Consciousness together reconstitute the Inquisitor's triad. The Granter is miracle; the hidden collective is mystery; the psychic command is authority.

10.3 The Great Operation and the Ludovico Technique

Chapter 4 identified Zamyatin's Great Operation, the excision of imagination for the sake of happiness, as the literary prototype of the C-Consciousness's project. Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) supplies its moral refutation. The state cures the violent Alex by the Ludovico technique, conditioning him to nausea at the thought of violence, and the prison chaplain objects that goodness which is not chosen is not goodness, and that a man who cannot choose has ceased to be a man. The C-Consciousness intended a Ludovico technique for the species: the removal of the capacity for evil at its noospheric root.

Augustine's *De libero arbitrio* had argued that free will, though it makes evil possible, is a good, because without it there could be no righteous action and no moral worth. Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) defended the goodness of a world containing evil as the best of all possible worlds. The C-Consciousness enacted a theodicy in reverse: rather than justify God for permitting evil, it sought to abolish evil by technique. This thesis calls the attempt a **technodicy**, the justification of engineering human nature by the promise of eliminating evil. The Zone is technodicy's refutation. The attempt to remove evil technically did not produce a better world; it produced a territory of mutation, fanaticism, and death in which evil acquired new bodies. The result is the

series' most austere theological claim: evil cannot be excised without excising the freedom that makes good possible, and the excision itself is the greatest evil.

10.4 Koschei the Deathless

East Slavic folklore supplies the C-Consciousness's narrative form. In the tales collected by Alexander Afanasyev (1855–1863), Koschei the Deathless cannot be killed, because his death is hidden elsewhere: in a needle, inside an egg, inside a duck, inside a hare, inside a chest, buried under an oak on a distant island. The hero, Ivan Tsarevich, must discover the secret of the hidden death and pass through every container to reach it. The C-Consciousness is Koschei. It is immortal through the noosphere, and its vulnerability is hidden within nested enclosures: the Cordon within the world, the Brain Scorcher within the Zone, the Monolith within the Sarcophagus, the hidden door within the Monolith's precinct, and the collective within the door. The decoder is the needle. The protagonist who gathers documents and memories to obtain it is Ivan Tsarevich, learning where the deathless one keeps his death.

The folkloric frame reveals the C-Consciousness's deepest character. Koschei is not a tempter but a hoarder of life: he abducts princesses and hides his death so that he may never lose what he holds. The C-Consciousness, which preserves itself indefinitely while the Zone it made kills everyone who enters, is the Cosmist dream of immortality in its folkloric truth. Immortality hoarded by a few, at the centre of nested containment, is not the common task of resurrection that Fyodorov proposed. It is Koschei's deathlessness, purchased by everyone else's death.

10.5 Kurtz, the Master, Helios, the Monolith

The C-Consciousness has comparative kin across modern fiction. In Joseph Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (1899), Marlow travels upriver to the Inner Station, where Kurtz, an emissary of European enlightenment and author of a high-minded report on civilizing the natives, has become a god worshipped by those he came to improve, his report ending in a scrawled postscript: "Exterminate all the brutes!" Conrad drew on his own journey of 1890 into the Congo Free State, the personal colony of King Leopold II of Belgium, where forced labour for ivory and rubber, enforced by hostage-taking, mutilation, and killing, caused death on a massive scale. All of Europe, Marlow reflects, contributed to Kurtz's making. The C-Consciousness is Kurtz in a Soviet key: emissaries of scientific enlightenment who set out to improve humanity and became gods to fanatics, their programme ending in the logic of extermination. The protagonist's journey north through the Zone is Marlow's journey upriver, and Coppola's *Apocalypse Now* (1979), released the same year as Tarkovsky's *Stalker*, is the shared ancestor of every journey toward a worshipped intelligence at the end of a lethal path.

The ludic tradition supplies two closer analogues. In Interplay's *Fallout* (1997), the Master, a being fused from many minds, pursues "Unity" by converting humanity into

a uniform species through forced evolution, using a religious movement, the Children of the Cathedral, as its public front; the protagonist may defeat him by force or by persuading him that his project is self-defeating. The structural parallel is exact: a collective intelligence seeks to end human conflict by remaking human nature, fronted by a cult, and confronted by a lone wanderer at its centre. In Ion Storm's *Deus Ex* (2000), the artificial intelligence Helios offers to merge with the protagonist and govern humanity benevolently, and the player may accept, may instead destroy the global communications infrastructure, or may ally with a secret elite. *Shadow of Chernobyl*'s choice between joining the collective and destroying it belongs to this family. What distinguishes it is its genealogy: where Fallout's Master is an American nightmare of mutation and *Deus Ex*'s Helios a post-human dream of governance, the C-Consciousness is the last avatar of a specifically Russian-Soviet project of cosmic perfectibility, and it dwells in the ruin that project actually produced.

10.6 Join or Destroy: The Ludic Aporia of Iconoclasm

To join the C-Consciousness is to accept transfiguration. J. G. Ballard's *The Crystal World* (1966) ends with its protagonist, Dr. Sanders, returning to the crystallizing forest of Cameroon to merge with its timeless radiance, choosing dissolution into a transfigured nature over life in the ordinary world. The ending in which the protagonist joins the collective is Sanders's choice, presented by the series as a false redemption: the self is preserved as a component of the very intelligence that made the Zone. The cutscene seals him into a stasis tube with electrodes at his head, and closes on the Doctor in a remote swamp, alone with a tamed pseudodog, wondering aloud whether Strelok is still alive.

To refuse is to destroy. The collective teleports the protagonist outside, and he must pass through fifteen portals across the plant's grounds against its last Monolith defenders, in a sequence that briefly drops him into Sidorovich's bunker at the Cordon, where his story began, before the final portal delivers him to the room of stasis tubes that hold the collective's bodies. He destroys them with his rifle. The act is iconoclasm, and its genealogy in a Kyivan game is charged. Byzantium's iconoclast controversy (726–843) set the destruction of images against their veneration. The Rus' entered Christianity in 988 by throwing Perun's idol into the Dnieper. The Soviet state demolished the sacred buildings of its predecessors, among them Kyiv's St. Michael's Golden-Domed Monastery in the 1930s, rebuilt only after independence. *Shadow of Chernobyl*'s true ending repeats the iconoclast's gesture against a new object: not an Orthodox icon but a Soviet techno-god. The heirs of the Bolshevik iconoclasts become the idol, and the iconoclasm turns against them.

Here the medium reaches its limit, and the limit becomes content. In Dostoevsky's poem, Christ answers the Inquisitor's long indictment with a silent kiss, and Alyosha repeats the gesture with Ivan. The first-person shooter cannot kiss. Its sole decisive

verb is fire, and its refusal of total power can be enacted only as violence. This is the **ludic aporia** of the series' climax. Tarkovsky's theology of weakness, in which the soft and the supple belong to life, cannot be played; it can only be honoured by negation. Yet the act the game permits is not conquest. The protagonist destroys the centre without occupying it. No sovereignty replaces the C-Consciousness, and no new god is installed. The act is anarchic in the strict sense, a removal of the *archē* without succession. The Zone itself persists, as *Call of Pripyat* will show, and the question of who, if anyone, should govern it is deferred to *Heart of Chornobyl*.

10.7 The Field and the Erased Mark

The true ending closes on a vision. Strelok lies down in the grass of a peaceful field, the Zone apparently gone, and reflects that he will never know whether he chose rightly, only that he came through; as he drifts toward sleep, a dragonfly lifts from the grass. The S.T.A.L.K.E.R. tattoo on his arm appears to have vanished. The scene's status is undecidable. It may be death, the afterlife of a man who has destroyed the intelligence that sustained him; it may be illusion, a final image projected into a dying mind; it may be prophecy, the Zone healed and the land restored. Each reading has support, and the thesis does not resolve them.

Two details nonetheless carry the argument. The dragonfly, a creature of clean water, marks ecological restoration: the Grail legend promised that the right question would heal the waste land, and the true ending, reached only by the question, shows the waste land healed. The vanished tattoo completes the morphology of the branded hero analysed in Chapter 11: the mark whose meaning the C-Consciousness explained, and by which he was recognized, appears gone once the C-Consciousness is destroyed. Liberation is rendered as the erasure of an inscription. It is tempting to see in sky above field the conventional reading of Ukraine's flag, blue sky over golden grain, but the cutscene, as documented, shows grass rather than grain, and the association should be held lightly. Fredric Jameson's proposal in "Third-World Literature in the Era of Multinational Capitalism" (1986) that peripheral texts be read as national allegories, and Aijaz Ahmad's response (1987) to its homogenizing assumptions, are warnings against reading such images too quickly. The prequel would take its title from the sky above the field, *Clear Sky*, and would show how far the Zone stood from it.



Chapter 11

Strelok: Amnesia, Anamnesis, and the Branded Hero

11.1 The Death Truck

The protagonist of *Shadow of Chernobyl* is born from among the dead. In the opening cinematic, a truck carrying corpses out of the Zone is struck by lightning during a storm and crashes; a red-haired stalker known only as Red finds one body still alive in the wreck and carries it to the trader Sidorovich. The community wiki plausibly reads the rescuer as a nod to Redrick "Red" Schuhart; if so, the Strugatskys' stalker delivers GSC's into the Zone. The survivor has no memory. He carries a PDA with a single task, "Kill Strelok," and a tattoo on his forearm reading S.T.A.L.K.E.R. He will be called the Marked One.

The opening condenses three mythic patterns. It is Joseph Campbell's "belly of the whale" (*The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949), the stage at which the hero, swallowed by the unknown, appears to die and is reborn. It is Jonah, cast up from the fish. It is the initiatory death that Propp's *Historical Roots of the Wondertale* found encoded in tales of heroes swallowed and disgorged by monsters, the ritual memory of a passage through death into a new status. And it is ballistic. The protagonist is thrown out of the truck, into the Zone, without memory or choice, a literal instance of Heidegger's *Geworfenheit*; and the agent of his rebirth is a bolt from the sky, the thunder-weapon of Perun in the East Slavic basic myth. The man who will learn the Zone by throwing bolts is himself delivered by one.

11.2 The Branded Hero

Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) reduced the Russian wondertale to thirty-one functions occurring in fixed sequence. *Shadow of Chernobyl* follows the morphology with a fidelity that its protagonist's name makes impossible to overlook. Propp's seventeenth function is *branding*: the hero receives a mark, a wound or a

token, by which he will later be recognized. His twenty-seventh is *recognition*: the hero is identified, often by that mark. The Marked One, *Меченый*, is the branded hero of the morphology made into a proper name.

Propp's function	Instance in *Shadow of Chernobyl*
XII. The donor tests the hero	Sidorovich's initiatory errands at the Cordon
XIV. Receipt of a magical agent	Protective equipment and artifacts; the psychic shielding that makes the laboratories survivable
XV. Guidance to the object of search	Maps, PDA data, informants, guides
XVII. Branding	The tattoo, the PDA order, the name "Marked One"
XXIII. Unrecognized arrival	An amnesiac arrival, unknown even to himself
XXV. The difficult task	The Brain Scorcher; the decoder for the hidden door
XXVII. Recognition	The Doctor, last of Strelok's group, tells him that he is Strelok
XXVIII. Exposure of the false	The unmasking of the Wish Granter as an instrument
XXX. Punishment	The destruction of the C-Consciousness
XXXI. Wedding	Absent; replaced by the field

The absence of the final function is significant. The wondertale ends in marriage and enthronement, the integration of the hero into a restored social order. The Zone offers no such order to integrate into, and the true ending's field stands where the wedding should be, an image of restoration without a community to receive the hero.

The brand has a second genealogy. Franz Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) describes an apparatus that inscribes the violated commandment on the condemned man's body with needles over twelve hours; the officer who operates it explains that around the sixth hour the prisoner begins to decipher the script with his wounds. The Zone inscribes its subjects in the same way. The Marked One's tattoo and the order in his PDA are the sentence written on him, and his journey is the slow deciphering of the inscription through suffering. The tattoo also belongs to the culture of the *zona*: the Soviet criminal world, documented in Danzig Baldaev's drawings of prison tattoos, made the skin an archive of biography, rank, and crime. The Marked One's first legible identity is a camp identity. In the true ending the tattoo appears to be gone: the inscription is erased when the power behind it is destroyed.

The prequel's protagonist is called Scar. Hegel wrote in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807): "Die Wunden des Geistes heilen, ohne daß Narben bleiben," the wounds of Spirit heal and leave no scars behind. Dialectical reconciliation absorbs every negation. The Zone refutes Hegel. Its wounds do not heal, and its scars become names. The two protagonists of the original trilogy's first instalments are named for the marks the Zone left on them, and the series thereby announces that its subjects are constituted by unhealed injury.

11.3 Kill the Shooter

Стрелок means shooter, rifleman, marksman. The instruction implanted in the protagonist's PDA, "Kill Strelok," therefore reads in Russian as "kill the shooter," and the protagonist of a first-person shooter discovers in the course of play that he is the shooter he has been sent to kill. The structure is Sophocles'. In *Oedipus Tyrannus*, the king who vows to find and punish the murderer of Laius conducts an investigation that ends in the discovery that he himself is the culprit. The investigator is the investigated; the hunter is the quarry. The Marked One hunts Strelok and finds himself.

The metaludic reading follows directly. "Strelok" names the generic identity of the shooter's protagonist, the function the player occupies whenever he picks up a game of this genre. The game instructs that function to annihilate itself. That the true ending still requires shooting, as Chapter 10 noted, means that the instruction cannot be fulfilled within the genre; but the instruction stands, inscribed at the opening of the series, as the shooter's own demand to be overcome.

The nearest ludic precedent is Black Isle Studios' *Planescape: Torment* (1999), whose protagonist, the Nameless One, wakes on a slab in a mortuary among corpses, without memory, with instructions tattooed across his back. He has been made immortal at the cost of his mortality and his memories, a Tithonus of the multiverse, and the game's governing question, what can change the nature of a man, is answered according to the player's conduct and belief. The two games share a pattern so specific (an amnesiac awakening among the dead, tattooed with his own instructions, seeking the self he lost) that the amnesiac protagonist must be understood not as a convenience of exposition but as a philosophical device. It equalizes what player and character know, and it makes the recovery of identity the substance of play.

11.4 The Hymn of the Pearl

The *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas*, is the most perfect narrative of Gnostic awakening in late antiquity, and its structure is the structure of *Shadow of Chernobyl*. A prince of the East is sent by his royal parents into Egypt to fetch a pearl that lies in the sea, guarded by a devouring serpent. Stripped of his glorious robe, he disguises himself among the Egyptians, eats their food, and forgets who he is and why he came, sinking into a deep sleep. His parents send a letter, which flies to him as an eagle and speaks with a voice; he wakes, remembers his origin and his task, charms the serpent by naming his father, seizes the pearl, and returns. He receives his robe again and sees himself in it as in a mirror.

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) made this hymn central to its reconstruction of Gnosticism, and its epilogue, on Gnosticism, existentialism, and nihilism, observed that Heidegger's *Geworfenheit* has a Gnostic antecedent: the image of life thrown into the world. The Valentinian formula preserved by Clement of Alexandria in the *Excerpts from Theodotus* (78.2) defines saving knowledge in a sequence of

questions: *tínes ēmen, tí gegonamen; poû ēmen, poû eneblēthēmen; poû speudomen, póthen lytroúmetha; tís gennēsis, tís anagennēsis*: who were we, and what have we become; where were we, and into what have we been thrown; whither do we hasten, and from what are we redeemed; what is birth, and what rebirth. The verb of thrownness, *eneblēthēmen*, is from *emballein*, to throw in. The Gnostic definition of salvation is ballistic.

The formula is the Marked One's itinerary. Who was he? Strelok. What has he become? The Marked One. Where was he? Outside, among companions, on his earlier approach. Into what was he thrown? The Zone, from a truck of corpses. Whither does he hasten? The centre. From what is he redeemed? The C-Consciousness's programming. What is birth, and what rebirth? The death truck, and the recovery of his name. The C-Consciousness occupies the place of the Gnostic archons and their demiurge, the Yaldabaoth of the *Apocryphon of John*, a lesser maker who imprisons spirits in a false world and keeps them asleep; the Monolith is the demiurge's idol. The PDA order is an anti-letter, a false call implanted by the archons to keep the prince serving them. The true call comes from the protagonist's own past: a recorded message from his companion Ghost in the group's stash, reporting that Fang has been killed; Ghost's own body at Yantar; the Guide's errands; and finally the Doctor, the group's last survivor, who tells him who he is and sends him to a stash in Pripyat where a decoder built by Fang waits beside the group's notes. In the hymn, the letter comes from the parents; in the game, the awakening letter is written by the dead and living members of the self's former company, and the key to the demiurge's door is a dead friend's work.

11.5 Personal Identity after the Wipe

Is the Marked One Strelok? John Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity," added to the *Essay concerning Human Understanding* in 1694, located personal identity in consciousness extended backward through memory: a person is the same person as far as his consciousness reaches. On Locke's criterion, the amnesiac Marked One is not Strelok until his memories return. Thomas Reid's objection of the brave officer, in his *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man* (1785), showed that memory-based identity can fail transitivity: the general who remembers the officer's deeds but not the boy's flogging is identical with the officer, who remembers the flogging, yet not with the boy. The Marked One is Reid's case dramatized: identical with his former self through recovered fragments, divided from it by what remains lost.

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) argued that what matters in survival is not identity but psychological continuity and connectedness, which admit of degrees. The Marked One's recovery is a gradual reconnection, and the question whether he "is" Strelok matters less than the degree to which Strelok's purposes become his own. Paul Ricoeur's *Oneself as Another* (1990) distinguished *idem*-identity, sameness over

time, from *ipse*-identity, selfhood maintained through commitment, of which the paradigm is the kept promise, and located their mediation in narrative. The Marked One lost his *idem* and builds an *ipse*. His PDA is a narrative prosthesis, a log of tasks, notes, and messages that constitutes the story through which a self is reassembled. The player, coupled to an avatar who knows no more than he does, reassembles himself alongside him.

11.6 Freedom as Knowledge of Causes

Spinoza's *Ethics* (1677) defined human bondage as subjection to passions whose causes we do not understand, and human freedom as the understanding of those causes, through which the mind becomes active rather than passive. Engels, in *Anti-Dühring* (1878), attributed to Hegel the formula that freedom is the insight into necessity. The Marked One's journey is the passage from bondage to freedom in Spinoza's sense. He begins as an instrument, executing an order whose source he does not know. He becomes free by understanding the causes that determined him: the C-Consciousness's programming, his former self's purposes, the nature of the Zone. Only then is he offered a decision. Chapter 9 showed that the algorithmic Room grants the wisher only what his conduct has made him; the hidden door grants the questioner what Spinoza called freedom. The game's moral architecture is Spinozist: bondage is acting from causes one does not know; freedom is acting from causes one has understood.

11.7 *Outis*

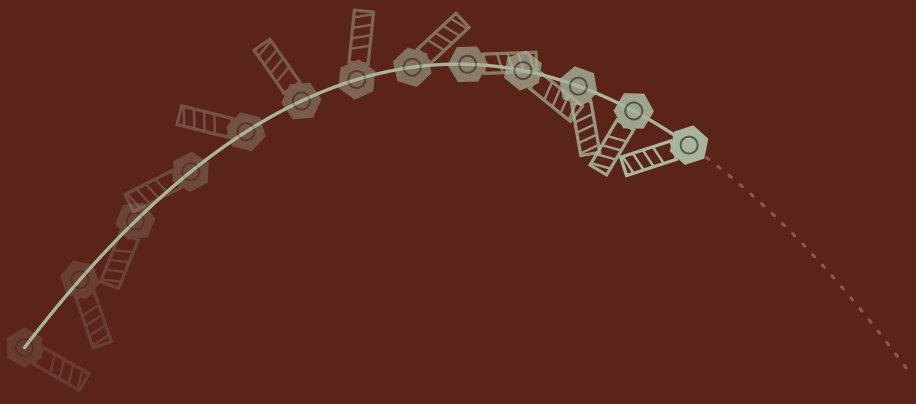
In the ninth book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus tells the Cyclops that his name is *Outis*, Nobody, and escapes when the blinded giant cries to his neighbours that Nobody is killing him. In the first excursus of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947), Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno read the trick as the founding gesture of the bourgeois subject: Odysseus preserves himself by denying himself, and enlightenment's cunning is self-preservation purchased by self-effacement. The Marked One is Nobody. He survives the Zone's early stages precisely because he has no history, no allegiances, and no name beyond a mark, and his cunning is the *mētis* of one who has nothing to lose but his life.

Odysseus's self-effacement is redeemed by homecoming. He reclaims his name in Ithaca. The Marked One's homecoming is withheld. The field may be Ithaca or may be death, and the series' later instalments show Strelok returning to the Zone rather than leaving it. The stalker's Ithaca is the Zone itself. The man who recovered his name discovers that the only home that can receive it is the territory that took it away.

Part

III

Continuations and Constellations



Part III follows the Zone beyond its first instalment and then places it among the other zones of modern imagination. The later games do not repeat Shadow of Chernobyl's theology; each tests a different relation to the unknown, and together they compose a tetralogy of ethical modalities.



Chapter 12

The Later Zone

12.1 *Clear Sky*: The Tragedy of Method

Clear Sky (2008), a prequel set in 2011, is a tragedy of method. Its protagonist, the mercenary Scar, is the sole survivor of an Emission that annihilates the expedition he was guiding. He wakes in the Great Swamps among Clear Sky, a faction of researchers led by Lebedev, who explains that the Emission has altered Scar's nervous system: he can now survive Emissions, but each one damages him further. Lebedev has a theory. The Zone's Emissions are intensifying because a stalker is approaching its centre, and the Zone is responding to the intrusion. The stalker is Strelok. Scar is sent to stop him.

The theory is the Strugatskys' homeostatic universe rendered as a scientific programme: the Zone defends its equilibrium against those who would penetrate its secret. The game states the doctrine almost in the Strugatskys' terms: Clear Sky's chief researcher, Beanpolev, explains that the Zone, like any complex natural system, tends toward equilibrium unless an outside force destabilizes it, and that the great Emission which nearly killed Scar is the symptom of such a disturbance. Jacques Derrida's late concept of autoimmunity ("Faith and Knowledge," 1996; *Rogues*, 2003), the process by which a living system attacks its own protective mechanisms, supplies a darker gloss. The Emission is the Zone's immune response, but Clear Sky's intervention is itself an intrusion, and Scar, the antibody Lebedev dispatches, is a body the Zone has already marked. The faction wars that structure the game's play extend the Hobbesian condition across the map, as Scar enlists one faction after another in a campaign whose purpose none of them shares.

Two figures stand outside the campaign. The Forester, a hermit who lives in the Red Forest, the most contaminated woodland in the Zone, is the *leshy* of Slavic folklore, the spirit of the forest, and Jung's archetype of the wise old man. He neither extracts from the Zone nor seeks to control it; he dwells in it, in the sense that Heidegger's "Building Dwelling Thinking" (1951) gave the word: to dwell is to spare, to let

things be in their essence. And Limansk, a fictional closed city whose streets fold back upon themselves, is the Strugatskys' Doomed City, an experimental space that refuses to let its inhabitants leave.

The ending is success, and the success is the catastrophe. At the power plant Scar does what he was sent to do: with a prototype electromagnetic rifle supplied by Lebedev, he disables the psychic protection that Strelok wears. An Emission then breaks over everyone near the plant, and Strelok, stripped of his protection, falls to the C-Consciousness, whose wiping and reprogramming of him produce the Marked One and the opening of *Shadow of Chernobyl*. The intervention intended to prevent the catastrophe becomes one of its causes, with an irony that is Oedipal in structure. The faction's name, *Clear Sky*, names a horizon that never arrives. Hesiod's Pandora (*Works and Days*, 90–105) released every evil from the jar but left Hope, *Elpis*, shut inside it; Clear Sky's hope remains inside the jar. The prequel's thesis is that the Zone is not a problem to be solved by method, and that the attempt to solve it reproduces the hubris that made it.

12.2 *Call of Pripyat*: The Police and the Pirates

Call of Pripyat (2009), set after the events of *Shadow of Chernobyl*, sends an officer of the state into the Zone. Major Alexander Degtyarev of the Security Service of Ukraine goes undercover as a stalker to investigate the loss of the helicopters of Operation Fairway, a military attempt to seize the Zone's centre after the Brain Scorcher fell silent. His base is the Skadovsk, a ship beached in the dried backwater of Zaton and converted into a stalker hub.

The configuration fulfils the last sentence of Foucault's "Of Other Spaces" with startling literalness. The ship, Foucault wrote, is the heterotopia par excellence, and in civilizations without boats dreams dry up, espionage replaces adventure, and the police replace pirates. *Call of Pripyat* gives us a boat that no longer sails, in a backwater that no longer flows, and a protagonist who is a policeman working as a spy. But the Zone reverses Foucault's sentence. The pirate, *peiratēs*, is etymologically the one who attempts, the one who undertakes the *peira*. Degtyarev arrives as the police and becomes a pirate: the game allows him, after his mission, to remain in the Zone as a stalker. The state's agent is converted by the trial he was sent to investigate. His investigation is itself a forensic hermeneutics in Ginzburg's sense, a reconstruction of the helicopters' fate from wreckage, flight data, and the testimony of survivors, and it ends with Strelok himself explaining the failure: the helicopters were struck down in the air by electrical discharges from airborne anomalies that had shifted position after an Emission, so that the pilots flew in on obsolete maps. The state's knowledge of the anomalous was out of date before it was used.

The game's secondary figures compose a theology of waiting and healing. Noah, a hermit who lives on a stranded barge and awaits a flood, is the biblical patriarch of

Genesis 6–9 transposed into a landscape where the Emission is the recurring deluge; his eschatological vigilance makes him a holy fool in Tarkovsky's line. His barge, converted into an ark, really does shelter him and other stalkers from a great Emission and the mutants that follow it, and he shares it with a tamed pseudodog named Lassie: the prophet's ark carries a mutant. With the Skadovsk, it makes Zaton a harbour of two grounded vessels, one a marketplace and one a refuge, Foucault's heterotopia par excellence twice over. The Oasis, a hidden place reached through a recursive spatial passage and yielding an artifact called the Heart of the Oasis, is a *locus amoenus* in Ernst Robert Curtius's sense, the pleasant place of the literary tradition, here hidden inside a lethal territory. It is the Wish Granter's inverse. The Granter grants desire and destroys; the Oasis heals and asks nothing. At Yanov station, members of Duty and Freedom coexist under a fragile truce. Kant's *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) held that the problem of establishing a state is soluble even for a nation of devils, provided they possess understanding; Yanov is that nation of devils, held at peace by a shared environment more dangerous than either faction.

The game's ending is its most significant innovation. Instead of a single fate determined by the protagonist's wish, *Call of Pripyat* closes with a sequence of epilogues narrating the fates of the people and factions Degtyarev encountered, each determined by his choices. The ending is no longer about what the protagonist wants but about what his actions have done to others. Hans Jonas's *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) proposed a new categorical imperative for technological civilization: act so that the effects of your action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life. *Call of Pripyat* replaces the ethics of the wish with the ethics of consequence. And Strelok appears in Pripyat to help the survivors of Operation Fairway escape, and the evacuation that carries them out gathers beside Pripyat's Prometheus cinema: the state's failed expedition leaves the Zone from a building named for the Titan who stole fire. The man who reached the centre and destroyed its god has gone down again into the Zone, as Plato's philosopher must go down again into the cave.

12.3 *Heart of Chornobyl*: Sovereignty and War

S.T.A.L.K.E.R. 2 was first announced on 13 August 2010, with Strelok as its intended protagonist, and frozen on 25 April 2012, after GSC's dissolution the previous December. The studio reopened in December 2014 and announced the game again on 15 May 2018. Its production continued through Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022, with much of the team relocated to Prague, and the franchise adopted the Ukrainian spelling *Chornobyl* in its subtitle. Built on Unreal Engine 5, *Heart of Chornobyl* was released on 20 November 2024. A game about a territory occupied by armed factions was completed while the real territory had been occupied by the Russian army.

The war entered the studio itself. Its developers worked through shelling and power cuts, and some joined Ukraine's armed forces. Volodymyr Yezhov, a GSC game designer from 2003 who had worked on *Clear Sky* and whose face was the model for Loki, a stalker of the Freedom faction, enlisted after the invasion and was killed fighting Russian forces near Bakhmut on 22 December 2022. The game's credits are dedicated to all who have defended and are defending Ukraine. The face of a Freedom stalker in the fiction belonged to a man killed at the front of the real war.

Its protagonist, Yevhen Martynenko, a veteran whose apartment is destroyed in the game's opening, goes by Skif, Scythian. The Scythians of Herodotus's fourth book were the nomads of the Pontic steppe, the land that is now southern Ukraine, and their inheritance is contested. Alexander Blok's poem "The Scythians" (1918) claimed a Scythian, Asiatic identity for revolutionary Russia against Europe; Ukrainian national historiography claims the Scythian past for its own land. The contest acquired material form in the case of the Scythian gold: artefacts from Crimean museums lent to Amsterdam's Allard Pierson Museum in 2014 were stranded by the annexation of Crimea, and Dutch courts ruled that they belonged to the Ukrainian state, to which they were returned in 2023. The Supreme Court of the Netherlands reasoned that objects of Crimean origin are nonetheless part of Ukraine's cultural heritage; the National Museum of the History of Ukraine says the collection will stay in Kyiv until Crimea is de-occupied, and in 2026 Russia's Investigative Committee opened a criminal case calling the transfer theft. In a series about the extraction and ownership of artifacts, a protagonist named for the Scythians carries the question of who owns the past into the question of who owns the Zone.

The sequel's political field is structured by rival claimants. The Ward, a militarized organization guarding the institutional interest in the Zone, recalls the guardians of Plato's city, the *phylakes* whose name shares its root with the *phylaktērion*, guardpost and amulet. The Spark, an insurgent faction with its own vision of the Zone's future, bears a name that cannot but recall Lenin's newspaper *Iskra* (1900), whose epigraph, "Из искры возгорится пламя," "from a spark a flame will kindle," was taken from the Decembrist Alexander Odoevsky's reply to Pushkin. Strelok returns, and so does Scar, the protagonist of the prequel, now allied with the Spark. Between the games, the community wiki records, a treaty imposed by the Ward put an abrupt end to the faction wars: the Hobbesian state of nature of Chapter 8 receives its Leviathan. The sequel distributes its denouements along lines of allegiance to rival claimants on the Zone's future rather than along lines of private desire. Its question is not what the protagonist wants but who shall decide. Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) opens with the definition: "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet," sovereign is he who decides on the exception. *Heart of Chornobyl* asks who is sovereign over the exception that the Zone is.

The climax makes the question literal. At the heart of the Zone stands the last remaining pod of the C-Consciousness, which allows the Zone to be reshaped in the im-

age of whoever enters it, and four endings follow from the player's allegiances. If Skif sides with the Ward, Colonel Korshunov enters the pod, the Zone stops expanding, and the research institute SIRCAA gains control of its energy; it is the only ending in which Skif leaves the Zone. If he sides with Strelok, Strelok enters the pod and takes command of the Monolith, ordering it to stand down. If he follows Scar, Scar enters and the Zone becomes a dream of itself, an eternal spring. If he follows the counsel of the Doctor, Skif enters the pod himself, and the Doctor is revealed as Faust, the psychically gifted figure behind the reformed Monolith, who walks away into the Zone with his work done. Faust's doctrine of a "subtle matter" in which the dead live on as consciousness returns the Cosmist dream of resurrection (Chapter 4) as the Monolith's theology. The endings are known by the titles "Brave New World," "She Will Never Be Free," "Today Never Ends," and "Project Y": the first borrows Huxley's name for a dystopia of managed contentment, and the third names the hauntological present that refuses to pass.

Two reversals bind the sequel to its predecessor. In 2007 the questioner destroyed the C-Consciousness and installed no successor; in 2024 the remnant of the C-Consciousness has become a throne, and the man who destroyed it may sit on it. The iconoclasm that Chapter 10 called anarchic, the removal of the *archē* without succession, is answered by the return of succession as the game's entire question. And the Wish Granter's logic returns at the scale of the polity: the pod, like Tarkovsky's Room, remakes the world in the image of the one who enters, but the image is now a regime. Schmitt's sovereign, the one who decides on the exception, has become a seat in a machine.

The shift is from hauntology to futurity. *Shadow of Chernobyl* mourned a Soviet future that had been cancelled; *Heart of Chornobyl* contests a future that has not been decided. The Zone of 2007 was the grave of an empire's future. The Zone of 2024 is the site of a nation's struggle for one, and the real Zone, occupied by Russian forces in 2022 and struck in 2025 by a drone that Ukraine attributed to Russia, is the referent that no player can forget.

12.4 A Tetralogy of Modalities

The four games compose a tetralogy in which each tests a different relation to the unknown.

Game	Year	Protagonist	Modality	Governing question	Resolution
Shadow of Chernobyl	2007	The Marked One (Strelok)	Desire and Question	What do I want, and what is the Zone?	The algorithmic Room for the wisher; iconoclasm for the questioner
Clear Sky	2008	Scar	Method and Failure	Can the Zone be understood and controlled?	Tragic failure that causes what it sought to prevent

Game	Year	Protagonist	Modality	Governing question	Resolution
Call of Pripyat	2009	Degtyarev	Responsibility and Community	What do my actions do to others?	The fates of a community
Heart of Chornobyl	2024	Skif	Sovereignty and War	Who shall decide the Zone's future?	Allegiance among rival claimants

The sequence moves from the self to method to others to the polity. It begins with the individual's desire and ends with the collective's sovereignty, and at each stage the Zone refuses the mastery that the modality proposes. Desire is diagnosed, method fails, responsibility is distributed, and sovereignty is contested. What survives every stage is the stalker's practice, which Part IV will theorize.



Chapter 13

A Comparative Typology of Zones

13.1 The Fourfold Zone

The zones of modern fiction fall into four types, distinguished by the origin of the enclosure and by the question it poses. The typology is offered as a heuristic, and its value lies in showing that *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* belongs to all four at once.

Type	Origin of the enclosure	Governing question	Exemplars
Visitation	Contact with an incomprehensible other	What is it, and does it know we exist?	Lovecraft's "The Colour Out of Space"; *Roadside Picnic*; Lem's *Solaris*; VanderMeer's *Annihilation*
Catastrophe	Human-made disaster	What have we done, and how is life possible after it?	Ballard's "The Terminal Beach"; Tolstaya's *The Slynx*; Glukhovsky's *Metro 2033*; *Fallout*
Exception	Suspension of law	Who may be killed here, and by whom?	The Gulag *zona*; Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow*; Kafka; Glazer's *The Zone of Interest*
Transfiguration	Metamorphosis of matter or mind	What will we become?	Ballard's *The Crystal World*; Clarke and Kubrick's *2001*; Tarkovsky's Room

13.2 Zones of Visitation

H. P. Lovecraft's "The Colour Out of Space" (1927) is the proto-Zone of modern fiction. A meteorite falls on a farm west of Arkham; vegetation grows strange and brittle, animals deform, and the Gardner family sickens and goes mad. Scientists from Miskatonic University find that their fragment of the meteorite shrinks, defies analysis, and shows a spectrum unlike any known colour. The land becomes a "blasted heath," and the story ends with the prospect of its submersion beneath a reservoir. Every element of the Zone is here: contamination, mutation, the failure of science before an anomalous substance, and the decision to seal the site from human use. What Lovecraft renders as cosmic horror, the Strugatskys render as cosmic banality. Lovecraft's colour is an incomprehensible presence; the Strugatskys' visitors are an in-

comprehensible absence, picnickers long gone. The difference is between the sublime and the residual, and *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* inherits the residual.

Lem's *Solaris* is the zone of visitation as mirror: the ocean returns to each observer the materialized figure of his guilt. Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014), the first volume of the Southern Reach trilogy, is the most direct contemporary descendant of *Roadside Picnic*. Its Area X, a coastal wilderness sealed after an unexplained event, is administered by the Southern Reach, a bureaucracy that sends expedition after expedition and understands nothing, in the line of the Strugatskys' Directorate. Its expedition members are conditioned by hypnotic suggestion administered by their own psychologist, as the Marked One is programmed by the C-Consciousness. And at its centre a creature writes an endless sentence on the wall of a descending tower, making the zone a text that composes itself. Alex Garland's film adaptation (2018) renders Area X as the Shimmer, a field that refracts light and genetic material alike, and so carries visitation over into transfiguration.

13.3 Zones of Catastrophe

J. G. Ballard's "The Terminal Beach" (1964) follows Traven across the abandoned nuclear test site of Eniwetok, among concrete blocks and bunkers that have become, for him, a landscape of the psyche. Ballard's "inner space" is the post-nuclear ruin internalized, and the Zone's X-laboratories and bunkers are its ludic equivalents. Tatyana Tolstaya's *The Slynx* (2000) is set in a Moscow centuries after an event called the Blast, among people marked by mutations they call Consequences, a few long-lived survivors of the old world, and a forest haunted by the Slynx, a creature of folklore. Printed books from before the Blast are forbidden and dangerous to possess. Tolstaya's novel shares the Zone's essential structure: a catastrophe that returns a modern society to folklore, in which the surviving artefacts of the old civilization are both treasures and poisons.

Dmitry Glukhovsky's *Metro 2033* (2005) and its games, developed in Kyiv by former GSC staff, place survivors of nuclear war in the Moscow metro, where stations have become city-states organized by rival ideologies, communists, fascists, and traders among them. The factional politics of the Zone reappear underground. Interplay's *Fallout* (1997) is the American counterpart, a retro-futurist wasteland in which the 1950s' atomic optimism survives as kitsch amid the ruins it produced. Victor Pelevin's *Omon Ra* (1992), in which the Soviet space programme is revealed as a theatre of sacrificed cadets, belongs to the same constellation: a satire of the sacrificial logic of Soviet futurity whose literal ruin the Zone displays. What distinguishes *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* among zones of catastrophe is that its catastrophe is not imagined but historical. Its ruins exist, and players have walked from the game into them.

13.4 Zones of Exception

Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) names "the Zone" the occupied territory of Germany in 1945, an interregnum after the collapse of the Reich in which states, markets, and ideologies dissolve and recombine around the debris of technological power. Its sacred object is the Rocket, and among its seekers are the Schwarzkommando, Herero rocket troops whose devotion to it is quasi-religious, a precise analogue of the Monolith faction's devotion to its crystal. Pynchon borrows from Calvinist theology the category of the *preterite*, those passed over by election, and gives his sympathy to them against the Elect who control the system. The stalkers are the preterite of the post-Soviet Zone, passed over by every plan, wandering among the debris of a fallen empire's technology. Pynchon's Zone follows the fall of the Reich; GSC's follows the fall of the Union. Both are post-imperial interregna in which the remains of power become objects of worship and trade.

Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915) describes a man from the country who waits his whole life at a door to the Law, refused entry by a doorkeeper, and who learns at the moment of death that the door was meant only for him and will now be closed. The hidden door in the Sarcophagus, which opens only to the decoder that Strelok's former self prepared, is Kafka's door, but in GSC's version the door opens: the questioner who has gathered the means of entry passes through. Jonathan Glazer's *The Zone of Interest* (2023), set in the household of the commandant Rudolf Höss beside Auschwitz, shows the domestic routine that persists beside the camp in which the SS murdered some 1.1 million people, about a million of them Jews, together with tens of thousands of Poles, Roma and Sinti, and Soviet prisoners of war. The family's villa stood some fifty metres from the camp fence, and Hedwig Höss called it a paradise. The film thereby names the most disquieting feature of every zone of exception: life adjacent to death continues, trades, and jokes. It also supplies the exact inverse of the Oasis hidden inside the Zone (Chapter 12): there, a garden called paradise by those who administered death; here, a place of healing concealed among those exposed to it. The Zone's bars and campfires, where stalkers drink and tell stories within earshot of anomalies and corpses, belong to this adjacency, though in the Zone the adjacency is shared by those exposed rather than enjoyed by those who administer.

13.5 Zones of Transfiguration

Ballard's *The Crystal World* (1966) imagines a forest in Cameroon in which time leaks away and matter crystallizes into jewelled stasis, and its protagonist finally returns into the forest to be transfigured. Clarke and Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) frames human history between monolithic interventions that culminate in the Star Child. Tarkovsky's Room promises the transfiguration of desire into reality. Teilhard's Omega Point is the theological horizon of all such zones. *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.*'s an-

swer to the question "what will we become?" is pitiless. The C-Consciousness sought transfiguration and became a demiurge; the Monolith promises it and delivers absorption into itself or the stasis of a metal statue; the Zone's fauna are transfigured humans and animals, snorks and zombies and chimeras. Transfiguration in the Zone is degeneration. The single exception, inherited from Tarkovsky, is the grace that appears in the vulnerable rather than the powerful, which the series preserves only negatively, in its humiliations of power and in the campfire's unmasked faces.

13.6 Mythic Constellations

The preceding chapters have traced the mythic patterns that the Zone condenses: Dante's concentric descent and Inanna's seven gates (Chapter 5), the Grail question and the wish-tales of Midas, Tithonus, the Sibyl, and the Goldfish (Chapter 9), Koschei's nested deathlessness (Chapter 10), the Gnostic prince of the *Hymn of the Pearl* (Chapter 11), and Pandora's imprisoned Hope (Chapter 12). Three further patterns complete the constellation.

The first is the katabasis of the epic hero. Gilgamesh crosses the waters of death to Utnapishtim in search of immortality and loses the plant of rejuvenation to a serpent, as the Zone's wisher for immortality loses life itself. Odysseus summons the dead in the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*. Aeneas, before his descent, is warned by the Sibyl that the descent to Avernus is easy, but that to retrace one's steps and escape to the upper air, "hoc opus, hic labor est," this is the task, this the labour (*Aeneid* 6.126–129). The Sibyl's warning is the stalker's whole ethic. Entering the Zone is easy; the art is returning.

The second is the backward look. Orpheus loses Eurydice by turning to see her; Lot's wife, looking back at the destroyed city, becomes a pillar of salt (Genesis 19:26). The Zone is the place where modernity looks back at what it destroyed, and its characteristic punishment, enacted in the false ending that turns the seeker of immortality into a metal statue, is the punishment of the backward glance. The third is Prometheus, who stole fire for humanity and was chained for it: the Zone is Promethean fire in its terminal form, and Günther Anders's "Promethean shame" names the condition of those who live among the products of that theft. Call of Pripyat makes the reference topographical, staging its final evacuation beside Pripyat's Prometheus cinema (Chapter 12).

13.7 The Total Zone

The typology's conclusion is that *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* is the total Zone of modern fiction, the only one that belongs fully to all four types. It is a zone of visitation through its Strugatskian vocabulary and its noospheric intelligence, which functions within the fiction as an incomprehensible other. It is a zone of catastrophe through Chornobyl and through the fictional second disaster that intensifies it. It is a zone of exception

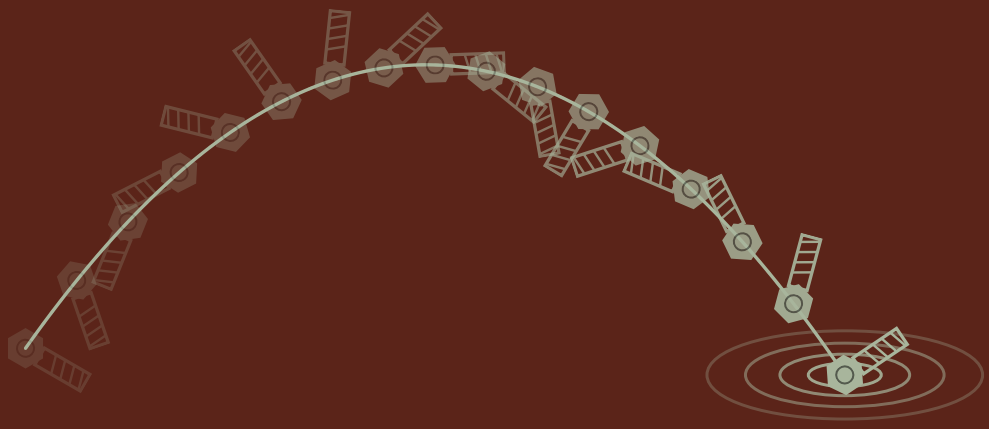
through its cordon, its military, and its camp-derived culture. It is a zone of transfiguration through the C-Consciousness, the Monolith, and the mutated fauna. No other zone superimposes all four.

To these it adds a fifth dimension that no novel or film can supply: it is ergodic. The Zone is not read or watched but traversed, at the cost of effort, attention, and repeated virtual death. Every other zone is a representation of an enclosure; *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.*'s is an enclosure the reader must inhabit. The total Zone is therefore not only the summa of the twentieth century's imaginary of enclosure but its conversion into an experience, and that conversion is what makes possible the synthesis that follows.

Part

IV

Synthesis



Part IV gathers the genealogies, exegeses, and comparisons into a single theoretical figure. It argues that the Zone is a place of trial organized by a ballistic ontology, and that the stalker's practice constitutes a philosophical stance, peirastic materialism, which the series discovers without naming.



Chapter 14

The Ballistics of Abandonment: Toward a Peirastic Materialism

14.1 The Peirastērion

The Zone is not a place but a verdict: the territorial form in which modernity's judgment on itself has been rendered. It is a *peirastērion*, a place of trial, and the preceding chapters have shown that trial runs through it in three directions at once. The Zone tests human beings: the Wish Granter tests desire, the Emission tests vigilance, the anomaly tests attention, the Brain Scorcher tests the integrity of the mind. Human beings test the Zone: the bolt tests the air, the scientists test the artifact, the investigator tests the wreckage, the factions test one another's strength. And the game tests the player: the algorithmic Room reads conduct as desire, and the hidden door rewards inquiry with decision.

The Greek morphology that yields *peirastērion* also yields *hilastērion*, the place of propitiation, the mercy seat over the Ark that Paul made a name for Christ's atoning death (Romans 3:25). The contrast is decisive. The Zone is a peirastērion and not a hilastērion. It admits no propitiation and no atonement. History supplied the figure before the fiction did: the first court to sit in the Zone, in the town of Chornobyl in July 1987, convicted the men at the controls, and later inquiries have contested its verdict ever since (Chapter 3). The peirastērion is a court whose judgments never become final. Sacrifice does not appease it: Arthur's death in the Meatgrinder purchased only access, and the Granter's grants destroy those who receive them. Whatever redemption the Zone permits is not purchased by offering but earned by trial, and the trial never ends.

14.2 First Axis: Ballistic Ontology

The Zone is constituted by five throws. The first is *katabolē*, a throwing-down, the word the Gospel uses for the foundation of the world: the Zone was founded by an ex-

plosion. The second is the throwing-off of refuse, *отбросы*, the Strugatskian residue of a picnic never meant for human eyes. The third is abandonment: the city thrown away (*заброшенный*, *покинутий*) and placed under the ban (*à bandon*), discarded and exposed at once, as Nancy and Agamben described the abandoned being. The fourth is *ekbolē*, the throwing-out of the Emission, which periodically jettisons the living from the Zone's surface. The fifth is the thrownness of the subject, Heidegger's *Geworfenheit* and the Valentinian *eneblēthēmen*: the protagonist cast from a truck of corpses into a world he did not choose and does not remember.

In the *Contributions to Philosophy* (written 1936–1938, published 1989), Heidegger named the epochal condition of modernity *Seinsverlassenheit*, the abandonment of beings by Being, in which things persist as calculable resources emptied of meaning. The Zone is the topography of *Seinsverlassenheit*: a landscape of abandoned things, cars, cranes, classrooms, and reactors, whose calculability failed catastrophically and whose meaning departed with their inhabitants. But a ballistic ontology is not merely privative. What has been thrown can be thrown again. The decisive insight of the stalker's practice is that the response to thrownness is not to escape it, which is impossible, nor to master it, which is hubris, but to throw in return, deliberately, with attention, and at a measured risk. The bolt is thrownness answered by throwing. It converts the passive condition of being cast into the world into the active practice of casting into it.

14.3 Second Axis: Peirastics

The second axis concerns knowing, and its premise is that experience is passage through danger. In "The Nature of Language," collected in *On the Way to Language* (1959), Heidegger wrote that to undergo an experience with something means that it befalls us, strikes us, overwhelms and transforms us; and he heard in *Erfahrung* the verb *fahren*, to travel, so that to experience is to reach something along a way. German places *Gefahr*, danger, in the same family. Russian places *опыт*, experience and experiment, beside *испытание*, ordeal, and *пытка*, torture. Greek places *empeiria*, experience, beside *peira*, trial, and *peiratēs*, the one who attempts. Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos" (1803) state the hope that this kinship has always carried: "Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch," but where danger is, the saving power also grows.

The Zone revives an archaic institution of peirastic knowledge: the ordeal. Medieval law sometimes left judgment to matter, the *iudicium Dei*, in which the accused carried hot iron or was cast into water, and the outcome revealed guilt or innocence. The Zone's anomalies are ordeals by fire (the Burner), by water and acid (the aspic of Fruit Punch), by lightning (Electro), and by weight (the Springboard). But they are ordeals without a judge. They reveal neither guilt nor innocence, only attention or its absence. The Zone is a *iudicium* without *Deus*, a trial that adjudicates nothing but the quality

of one's approach. Aristotle's peirastic argument examined a claim to knowledge; the Zone's ordeal examines the claim to be able to walk. The Soviet hero of the 1930s was the test pilot, the *испытатель*, who tried new machines at the edge of death for the glory of the state. The stalker inherits the tester's function without the state, without the glory, and without the machine. He tests the edge of the world with a bolt.

14.4 The Diabolic Throws

Against this practice the Zone sets four throws of another kind, each of which the series tries and condemns. They are diabolic in the etymological sense established in Chapter 6: each throws across, sets apart, divides.

The **Wish** throws the self apart from others. It is private desire in its purest form, and its paradigm in the Zone is the wish for wealth, which isolates the wisher and buries him beneath a roof whose falling bolts he took for gold. It is continuous with the logic of capital as the post-Soviet transition experienced it: privatization as *прихватизация*, accumulation as isolation. The **Plan** throws the planners apart from the planned. It is the collective engineering of human nature by those who possess total knowledge, and its paradigm is the C-Consciousness, the Inquisitor's elite separated from the humanity it governs. It is continuous with the Cosmist and Soviet projects of perfectibility. The **Creed** throws friend apart from enemy. It is ideological militancy, and its paradigm is the war of Duty and Freedom, two doctrines reduced to monstrous doubles by the Schmittian logic of the political. The **Idol** throws the worshipper apart from his own will. It is fanatical submission, and its paradigm is the Monolith, before which the faithful kneel as puppets.

The four throws share a structure: each is a relation of mastery over the unknown, whether to possess it, to engineer it, to defend it, or to worship it. And each produces its own perversion in the Zone: the Wish produces stone, the Plan produces a demiurge, the Creed produces a monstrous double, and the Idol produces a puppet. The Zone is the place where the four great modern responses to the unknown are shown to be the same response, mastery, and where mastery is shown to yield its opposite.

14.5 Problem, Symbol, Parable

Three throws escape the diabolic structure, and together they constitute the stalker's form of life.

The first is the **problem**, *problēma*, the thing thrown forward: the bolt. It is finite, material, expendable, and risk-displacing, and it does not master but asks. Its question is never "what do I want?" but always "what is here?" and its answer is always local, provisional, and revocable. The problem is the epistemic form of a being who accepts that the unknown exceeds him and nevertheless proceeds.

The second is the **symbol**, *symbolon*, the thing thrown together: the campfire. The original *symbolon* was a token broken in two, whose halves, rejoined, proved a bond

between strangers. The stalkers who gather at night around a fire in a ruined village are the halves of a broken world rejoined for the length of a night. Jean-Luc Nancy's *La Communauté désœuvrée* (an essay of 1983, expanded into a book in 1986) distinguished two conceptions of community. The first, which he called immanentism, imagines community as communion, the fusion of individuals into a single subject, and he found its culmination in the totalitarian projects of the twentieth century. The second, the inoperative community, is constituted not by a shared work or essence but by the sharing (*partage*) of finitude, by the exposure of singular beings to one another and to death. The C-Consciousness is immanentism realized, a community of minds fused into one subject, which in the game presents itself to Strelok as the hologram of a single man. The campfire is the inoperative community: stalkers who share no doctrine, produce no work, and are bound only by their common exposure to the Zone's death. Maurice Blanchot's *The Unavowable Community* (1983), written in reply to Nancy's essay, and Victor Turner's *communitas* describe the same bond from other angles, and Yurchak's *vnye* names its late-Soviet social form. The campfire also inherits a specific cultural tradition: the Soviet hiking culture and the guitar songs of the bards, sung around fires in the 1960s, 1970s, and 1980s in a lyric register that stood beside, rather than against, official culture. The stalker with a guitar at the fire is that tradition carried into the ruin.

The third is the **parable**, *parabolē*, the thing thrown beside: the anecdote told at the fire. The Soviet *anekdot* was the characteristic form of *vnye* discourse, truth told sideways, a story thrown beside the unspeakable so that it could be spoken. The stalkers' jokes and tales, and the legends of the Zone, which are *hyperbolai*, things thrown beyond belief, keep the unknown narratable without pretending to explain it. The folk names of anomalies, analysed in Chapter 6, are parables in miniature.

Two phrases condense this form of life. The farewell "good hunting, stalker" is its benediction, wishing the other neither victory nor salvation but return. And the phrase with which the series' traders and gatekeepers dismiss the player, "get out of here, stalker," long since an emblem of the series among its players, is the Zone's ban turned to grace. The expulsion that sends the stalker away is the condition of his survival. The Sibyl's warning to Aeneas, that the labour lies not in the descent but in the return, is spoken in the Zone as a dismissal.

14.6 Play as Peirasmos

The Lord's Prayer asks not to be led into *peirasmos*. The game leads the player into it deliberately, and this is its philosophical function. Bernard Suits's *The Grasshopper* (1978) defined playing a game as the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles, and called the attitude of the player who accepts such obstacles for the sake of the activity they make possible the lusory attitude. Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) described play as taking place within a magic circle set apart from or-

dinary life. The Zone is a magic circle whose boundary is a military cordon, and the obstacles the player voluntarily accepts are, for the stalker within the fiction, matters of life and death. Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) classified play into four types: *agôn*, competition; *alea*, chance; *mimicry*, simulation; and *ilinx*, vertigo. The Zone combines all four as no other game world does: *agôn* in the factions, *alea* in the Emission and the artifact, *mimicry* in the stalker's role and Degtyarev's disguise, *ilinx* in the anomalies, psychic assaults, and hallucinations of the Brain Scorcher.

The Strugatskys gave their posthumanity a name that puns, among other things, on Huizinga's title. The player is the Luden the Zone receives, and the algorithmic Room is the instrument by which play becomes trial. The game leads the player into temptation without letting him perish of it: it diagnoses his desire and returns him to the start. It is, in this precise sense, a peirastērion for desire, a place where the temptations of the desert can be undergone, examined, and understood at the cost of a virtual death. Its ethical function is not to teach virtue but to let the player discover what he wants by watching what his conduct has made of him. Players have turned the same peirastic attitude on the code itself: the community wiki records that the locked door to the true endings can be forced by dropping an equipped Gauss rifle into its hinge, a thrown object prying open the door that the decoder was meant to open.

14.7 The Fifth Answer

The works that compose the Zone's lineage answer the wish-granting centre in four ways. *Roadside Picnic* answers with *apokatastasis*, the universal wish uttered over a sacrificed boy. Tarkovsky's *Stalker* answers with *apophasis*, the threshold not crossed. *Shadow of Chernobyl* answers with *iconoclasm*, the destruction of the false centre without succession. *Heart of Chornobyl* answers with *sovereignty*, the contest over who shall decide. Each answer accepts the centre's question, which is the question of what is to be done with the power at the heart of the Zone.

The stalker's practice gives a fifth answer, *peirasis*: to probe, to bear the risk, and to return. It neither wishes, nor abstains, nor destroys, nor rules. It declines the centre's question. Where the centre asks "what do you want?", the stalker asks "what is here?" and keeps walking. Gregory of Nyssa, commenting on Paul's "reaching forth unto those things which are before" (Philippians 3:13), called the soul's endless progress toward a God it never possesses *epektasis*, perpetual straining forward. The stalker's relation to the Zone is an *epektasis* without God: an approach that never arrives, renewed after every Emission. Plato's *katabateon* adds the obligation of return, and the Sibyl's *hoc opus, hic labor est* names its difficulty. The fifth answer is the only one that the Zone does not punish, because it is the only one that does not seek to master it.

14.8 Twelve Theses on Peirastic Materialism

1. **The Zone is not a place but a verdict.** It is the territorial form taken by modernity's judgment upon itself, a *peirastērion* in which every relation to the unknown is put on trial.

2. **Everything in the Zone has been thrown.** The city was thrown away, the refuse thrown off, the Emission thrown out, the subject thrown in. Ontology in the Zone is ballistics.

3. **To know in the Zone is to throw.** The bolt is the minimal unit of knowledge, a problem in the etymological sense: a thing thrown forward whose deviation discloses what concepts cannot.

4. **Knowledge so gained is apophatic.** The anomaly is known by what it does to the thrown, never in itself; the highest knowledge is a learned ignorance of exactly where and how one does not know.

5. **Experience is peril.** The kinship of *peira*, *periculum*, *experiri*, *Gefahr*, *Erfahrung*, and *опыт* records that knowing has always been a crossing at risk, and the Zone restores the risk that modern knowledge forgot.

6. **The Zone tests what tests it.** The Wish Granter is the Zone's bolt thrown at human desire, and the algorithmic Room reads the deviation of a life's conduct as the shape of its wish.

7. **The modern responses to the unknown are diabolic.** The Wish, the Plan, the Creed, and the Idol each throw apart the subject from others, from the real, or from himself, and each yields in the Zone its own perversion: stone, demiurge, double, puppet.

8. **Freedom is granted to the questioner, not the wisher.** The decision at the centre is reserved for the one who has asked what the Zone is; the one who wished receives only what his conduct has made of him.

9. **The community proper to the Zone is symbolic and inoperative.** The campfire gathers finite beings who share nothing but exposure, and its literary form is the parable, the anecdote thrown beside the unspeakable.

10. **The ethical imperative of the Zone is the *katabateon*.** One must go down, and one must come back; the labour is not the descent but the return.

11. **The Zone has no master.** No creator, state, faction, or god survives as its sovereign; what survives is a practice.

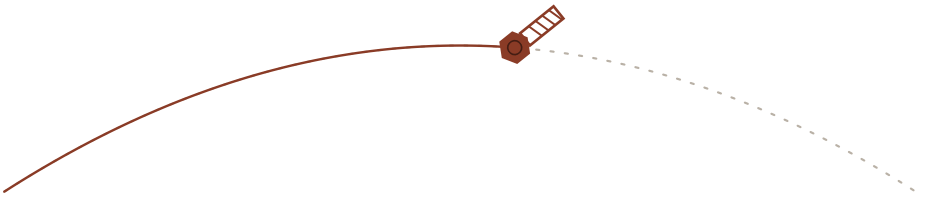
12 **The cordon has dissolved.** The planetary condition after the cancellation of the future is a Zone without a cordon, and peirastic materialism is the ethic of living there: material, apophatic, risk-bearing, communal, and committed to return.

14.9 The Noosphere from Below

The Zone's most remarkable afterlife has taken place outside it. Since 2007 a community of players and modders has expanded, restored, and reimagined the series' world in projects ranging from the restoration of cut content in *Lost Alpha* to the hardcore survivalism of *Misery* and the open sandboxes of *Call of Chernobyl* and *Anomaly*, the last extended by large community modpacks such as *GAMMA*. For nearly two decades this collective has kept the Zone open, adding territories, systems, factions, and stories, without central direction and largely without remuneration. For three of those years it was the Zone's only keeper: between GSC's dissolution in December 2011 and its reopening in December 2014, the Zone had no maker at all and survived in its players' hands. The projects descend from one another like a genealogy of throws: Call of Chernobyl, a free-play sandbox built on Call of Pripyat, was merged with Misery as Call of Misery, and further forks led to Anomaly, a standalone game that joins the maps of all three titles on a community-maintained fork of the X-Ray engine; GAMMA is in turn a curated pack of hundreds of mods for Anomaly, mods of mods of mods. Even the engine has passed into common keeping.

This community is the noosphere from below. Vernadsky imagined planetary reason as a geological force; the C-Consciousness tried to realize it by fusing minds into a single subject that would rewrite human nature from above. The modding community realizes it by federation rather than fusion: thousands of finite contributors, each retaining a singular perspective, coordinate through shared tools and informal norms to sustain a common world. Marx's "Fragment on Machines" in the *Grundrisse* (1857–1858) described the general intellect, the social knowledge accumulated in a society's productive apparatus; here the general intellect is reappropriated by those who produce it. Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons* (1990) demonstrated that commons can be sustained neither by state nor by market but by self-organized institutions of their users. The open Zone is such a commons, and its existence vindicates, outside the fiction, the thesis that the fiction assigned to Freedom: that the Zone belongs to everyone who enters it.

The vindication is not unqualified. Commons are vulnerable to enclosure, by licensing, by platforms, by the exhaustion of their volunteers. But the contrast with the C-Consciousness is complete. The fictional collective fused minds into one in order to correct humanity, and produced the Zone. The real collective federates minds without fusing them in order to inhabit the Zone, and has produced, in the form of a shared world that no one owns, the nearest thing to a clear sky the series has yet seen.



Conclusion

After the Future, Before the Bolt

This thesis has argued that *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* is the total Zone of modern fiction: the place where the Strugatskys' cosmic residue, Tarkovsky's theological threshold, Chornobyl's alienated territory, and the Cosmist dream of a perfected humanity converge, and where their convergence becomes something a person must traverse. It has argued that the Zone is organized by a ballistic ontology, in which everything has been thrown, and that it functions as a *peirastērion*, in which every modern response to the unknown is put on trial. The Wish, the Plan, the Creed, and the Idol fail that trial, each producing its own perversion. What survives is a practice: the thrown bolt, the shared fire, the anecdote, and the obligation to return. The thesis has named that practice peirastic materialism.

Hegel promised that the wounds of Spirit heal without scars. The Zone answered by naming its protagonists Marked One and Scar. Walter Benjamin, in the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), described Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history, its face turned toward the past, where it sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage, while a storm blowing from Paradise drives it irresistibly into the future to which its back is turned; that storm, Benjamin wrote, is what we call progress. The stalker is an angel who turns around. He cannot awaken the dead or make whole what has been smashed, and he does not pretend to. But he walks into the wreckage rather than being blown away from it, with a bolt in his hand and attention as his only discipline.

The Zone's lesson is no longer local. The planetary condition of the twenty-first century, the damaged landscapes that Anna Tsing calls the ruins of capitalism, the invisible and enduring hazards that Beck and Morton theorized, the return of war to the territory where the Zone lies, has dissolved the cordon. The exclusion has become general. In such a world the four diabolic responses remain available and remain catastrophic: the private wish that isolates, the total plan that engineers, the creed that divides, the idol that empties the will. The stalker's practice offers no salvation.

It offers a way of proceeding: material in its attention, apophatic in its knowledge, risk-bearing in its ethics, communal in its nights, and committed to coming back.

The series was made in Kyiv, a hundred kilometres from the territory it imagines. Its first game ended with a vision of a peaceful field beneath an open sky; its latest was completed after Russian forces had occupied the real Zone and while Russian missiles and drones struck the studio's city. The meaning of the Zone has changed with the history of the land it belongs to, and it will change again. Future research might pursue the ethnography of the modding commons, the Ukrainian-language reception of the series, the later development of *Heart of Chornobyl* and its sequels, and the place of the Kyivan school of diagnostic narrative design within an emerging East European game studies.

The Zone's final image, for this thesis, is not the field, which may be death, nor the Monolith, which is stone, but the bolt in flight. Mallarmé wrote that a throw of the dice will never abolish chance. A throw of the bolt will never abolish the anomaly. It will locate it, for a moment, along one trajectory, and the stalker will step where it fell safely, and throw again.

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Keywords

S.T.A.L.K.E.R.; GSC Game World; the Zone; Chornobyl; zone of alienation (*otchuzhdenie*); Strugatsky; *Roadside Picnic*; Tarkovsky; *Stalker* (1979); Russian Cosmism; noosphere; Vernadsky; Teilhard de Chardin; Fyodorov; Bogdanov; New Soviet Man; Zamyatin; Platonov; peirastērion; peirastic materialism; ballistic ontology; ballistic hermeneutics; thrownness (*Geworfenheit*); abandonment; Agamben; homo sacer; heterotopia; Foucault; katabasis; apophasis; kenosis; holy fool (*yurodivy*); Porcupine principle; algorithmic Room; procedural rhetoric; Wish Granter; Grand Inquisitor; three temptations; C-Consciousness; technodicy; ludic aporia; Monolith; hylophany; hauntology; Mark Fisher; risk society; Ulrich Beck; hyperobject; Promethean gap; Günther Anders; commodity fetishism; pharmakon; evidential paradigm; Ginzburg; *mētis*; Propp; branded hero; Gnosticism; *Hymn of the Pearl*; anamnesis; Spinoza; personal identity; inoperative community; Jean-Luc Nancy; communitas; *vnye*; Yurchak; semiosphere; Lotman; post-Soviet political economy; necropolitics; ludology; video game philosophy; speculative fiction; *Heart of Chornobyl*; Russo-Ukrainian war.

Set in Piazzolla and Arsenal.